Dagger And Heart

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/46037440.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Modern AU but still Canon Species, Childhood Friends, Adult reunion, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Oblivious Adora (She-Ra), Oblivious Catra (She-Ra), Fake Marriage, Friends to Lovers, NaNoWriMo 2022, Idiots in Love, Adora is Catra-sexual, Honeymoon, Implied Sexual Content, Fluff, Reunion, Nudity

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by WordsAreTheyTo BeRead

Summary

Adora grins. She stares deep into Catra's eyes and says, "Challenge."…
"accepted."
Everyone else groans and protests and whines and whatnot.
Catra winks at Adora. "Race you to wherever people marry ."
She jumps up from her chair and darts to the front door , Adora hot on her heels.
"Right now?" Bow asks in disbelief.
"You are insane," Glimmer calls after them.
Catra and Adora giggle like the little girls they once were as they burst through the front door in the race for a pot of gold.

OR

After life separated Catra and Adora nine years ago, chance brought them back together. The flame of their friendship rekindles as if no time had passed at all. Things change, however, when their friends suggest a bet the two just cannot resist: who of their circle of friends will be the first to marry?

Notes

Welcome to this little story of mine and thank you for stopping by. It's already finished, and I will post a new chapter every week.

Please make sure you have work skins enabled (should be the default) because I used small caps to indicate a certain kind of nonverbal communication. Unfortunately, the default skin doesn't support small caps. If you have it enabled, these texts should look differently:

- Normal text
- Small caps text

If you have a little time and a few words to spare, please drop your thoughts and/or feels about the story in the comments. I welcome constructive criticism.

With that out of the way, I dearly hope you enɲy the story .

Chapter 1

Saturday, 9 January 1

Adora grumbles after reading Glimmer's text. Why do they always have to be late? It's bad enough that Glimmer invited herself and Bow to watch *She-Ra: Knight Fall At Doom's Day* at the cinema. Adora would rather go alone than feeling like an intruder to what will turn into a date between her friends. It's not like she didn't tell them exactly that, but they, like they always do, brushed it off because "going alone to the cinema is just so sad."

Well, in the end, it *is* her own fault because she can't stand up to them when they're relentless like that. With a sigh, she gets in line for the tickets. In front of her are what looks like a group of five friends, chatting about how excited they are to see *Quick & Raging 13*. Definitely not Adora's cup of tea.

A little further down the line, a furry tail sways to the side. Feline. Adora's heart skips a beat. A burly guy hides the tail's wielder from her sight. Undeterred by the fact that the tail is orange and white striped, not dark brown like Catra's, Adora tries to sneak a peek of the Feline without making her interest too obvious. The tail's tip twitches a little, signalling excitement for whichever film they have in mind. Or maybe they are nervous because they are on a date?

The guy shifts to the side when the line advances, and Adora glimpses the Feline. A male. She heaves a sigh. However slim the chances are to run into Catra after all these years, she just can't help hoping. On top of that, Catra's been on her mind all day: They've seen the first *She-Ra* film, what, thirty times back then? She still has the old tape with Catra's scratch marks from the day it got stuck in the VCR.

Watching the newest instalment without Catra is probably the main reason Adora's grumpy about Glimmer and Bow. They can't possibly

replace her. There was a time Adora hoped Glimmer could at least come close to what Catra and her had, but that hope burned to ashes once Glimmer and Bow got together and became each other's top priority.

Adora distracts herself with playing *Crawly Cat* on her phone until she's next in line and buys three tickets. Most seats are still available. The declining interest in the series is a shame, and if this one performs even worse at the box office than its predecessor, it will probably the last *She-Ra* movie. If only she could watch the first one for the first time again with Catra by her side.

Well, at least their seats will grant them a good viewing experience.

Tickets in her pockets and at least ten more minutes until Glimmer and Bow arrive, Adora visits the ladies' toilet. Today, as it turns out while she sits in her stall, is one of these days where it just trickles and trickles and trickles with neither haste nor end.

Is that a hole in the back of her panties? Not again. Maybe Perfuma was right, and Adora's washing machine has a sharp edge somewhere. She doesnt want to throw otherwise impeccable panties away and buy new ones because of a silly little hole that, in all honesty, no one will see anyway. Except her doctors. If this goes on, though, shell soon have not a single intact pair left.

Someone calls her name from where the sinks are. That voice! It sounds exactly like Adora imagines adult Catra would nowadays. It's silly because they were ten the last time they saw each other. There' s no way Adora could predict how Catra's voice would develop.

Still.

'Are you here?' they voice asks, softer now , as if afraid to wake a ghost.

Adora's mouth is dry. Despite how awkward talking in a toilet of all places is and through the door of a stall without even seeing one another no less, she says, "I'm here."

The tap-tap of bare feet against floor tiles draws near. Adora holds her breath. Claws scratch against Adora's door. Her gaze follows the sound as it scrambles higher until a head pops up over the rim. One turquoise eye and one yellow, both wide, stare at her.

"Catra," Adora gasps. "Is this real?"

The head nods eagerly.

Adora's heart races. It can't be. Were the mushrooms she added to her risotto magic ones? Did she fall asleep while waiting for Glimmer and Bow? But these eyes …

Loud voices cut through the silence, startling Adora and Catra, too, given how her eyes grow even wider. With the speed of lightning, Catra throws herself over the rim and lands with barely a sound inside Adora's stall. She's close enough that Adora could touch her.

They stare at each other while the intruders' voices – two, maybe three girls from the sound of it – move around until the door of a stall further down the room slams shut. It dampens the animated chatting, but not much. Are they taking turns inside there?

Oh. Adora's still doing her business, jeans and panties pulled down to her knees. Catra stands ramrod straight, covers her eyes and turns around, facing a corner. And Adora bursts into laughter like a lunatic. She laughs until she gets dizzy, but she still catches Catra throwing her a side-glance, tail twitching with nervous energy.

So Adora finishes up. It's strange, like her mind lags a heartbeat behind her body, like watching a video where sound and vision are out of synch. When she walks out of the stall, the skin on her back tingles as if telling her that Catra follows behind. A look into the mirror by the sinks confirms that Catra indeed is on her heels.

When Adora looks down to wash her hands, she loses sight of Catra. Halfway expecting the mirror to be empty were she look up again, she instead turns around while holding her breath and eyes fixed on the floor. Catra's feet are in front of her, and Catra's tail keeps twitching.

Biting her lip, Adora raises her head. "I see you're still not grossed out by the floor of a semi-public toilet."

"And I see," Catra says, a smirk playing around her lips, "you still have that silly hair poof."

Adora smiles. "It reminds me of you." They fought over it the first day they met each other on the playground until they were rolling in the dirt. From the second day on, they were inseparable. "It was the catalyst of us."

Catra chuckles. "No, it wasn't."

What? Not?

Catra shifts her weight. "I just needed an excuse to hate you because I was jealous of your fancy toys."

Adora gasps. "The cat face sand mould?"

"The cat face sand mould," Catra says with a smile, finally at ease. It's so pretty it tugs at Adora's heartstrings.

"You never told me."

Catra shrugs. "I was a dumb kid, and eventually , it didn't matter any more."

Adora snorts. "So what you're saying is, I should have kept the sand mould instead of the poof?"

"It's gone." Catra's pout is a punch to the gut.

"Stars, I actually don't know. Maybe somewhere in my mum's attic? I'll have a look next time I visit her."

"It's okay, it's just a silly toy." Catra's face disagrees, and Adora will definitely search the attic. "How is she, by the way? And your dad?"

Adora winces. "She's fine, but he died shortly after ... you-know-who took you away."

Pain contorts Catra's face. "Shit, I'm sorry." She squeezes Adora's arm.

Adora's breath hitches, and she turns to Catra's hand.

"Oh," Catra says, drawing her hand back, "I didn't—"

Adora reaches for Catra's hand, grabs it midair and places it on her cheek, pushes into Catra's palm. They always did that to comfort each other. She closes her eyes and sighs. "Let's stay in touch this time."

"Of course," Catra whispers.

The chatting group emerges from its stall: three teenage girls, maybe about two years younger than Adora. They throw Catra and her weird looks, Catra's hand still on Adora's cheek, when they pass them on their way to the sinks.

Adora shrugs them off. "I tried to find you, you know?"

"I know."

"You do?"

Catra chuckles. "I always knew you would. I did the same, but I couldn't get past you-know-who's security."

"That's what I assumed." Adora cups Catra's cheek with her free hand, and Catra leans into the touch. "We moved back to Eternia

after Ed died, so you wouldn't have had any luck, anyway."

Catra hums. "I found out you moved after I was—" She looks around, but the girls left, and they seem to be alone. "After I was adopted."

"You were?"

Catra nods, eyes and ears saying she got into a nice family.

Adora pulls her into a hug. "I'm so happy for you." She wraps her arms even tighter around Catra, and Catra does the same, snuggling her face against Adora's neck.

"I missed you," they both say at the same time.

"So much," Adora adds. "I demand"—

"at least five hugs every day," Catra finishes for her, making them both chuckle. "I met my quota most days, didn't I?"

"You did." Unless one of them was terribly ill, they saw each other daily. Adora squeezes Catra once more with a sigh before letting her go. Then, the questions bubble up her throat. "What do you do here? The new *She-Ra*? Do you live here or are you just visiting? How long do you stay? Want to mess with my friends?"

Catra giggles. "The last one is a bit surprising."

Adora grins. "They insisted on coming along, although I would have been totally fine going on my own. And they made me wait."

"Then screw them," Catra says with a smirk.

Adora squeezes Catra's shoulder. "But really, do you live in Bright Moon? *Please say yes*."

"I moved here to study a few weeks ago."

"Y es," Adora calls and engages hug number two. A brief one. "I'm studying adult education here, what about you?"

"Industrial engineering." Catra huf fs. "Look, how about we catch up later? I mean, if you still want to watch that film."

"Oh, of course. Here," Adora says and produces her phone, "put in your number." She winks. "I wont let you get away again."

After exchanging numbers, they do come up with a plan to mess with Glimmer and Bow: Catra will pretend to be Adora while Adora hides somewhere and records the encounter. Adora pulls Catra's hoodie over her head while Catra slips into Adora's jacket. At Catra' s insistence, Adora forgoes her ponytail and poof, becoming totally unrecognisable. After showing Catra pictures of Glimmer and Bow and swapping their phones, they start a call. That way Adora can listen in to the conversation and drop Catra hints. Since Catra's ears are so sensitive, Glimmer and Bow wont hear a thing as long as Catra doesnt put the call on speaker .

Prepared like that, they enter the lobby where Glimmer and Bow wait for Adora. Adora spots them easily, sitting at one of the many tables. She sits down a few tables apart, too far away for them to recognise her in her disguise but close enough to obtain a good recording.

Catra approaches Glimmer and Bow's table, copying Adora's gait, and flops down on a free chair. "Hey , guys," she says through the speaker of the phone and waves, a gesture that looks so unlike Catra that Adora already has to suppress a laughter.

Even from here, Glimmer's frown is clearly visible. "Who are you?"

"Ha, ha. Y ou want some snacks?"

"That' s Adora's jacket," Bow says.

"Y eah, of course it's my jacket."

"You're not Adora, jackass," Glimmer says, reliably resorting to insults.

Catra snorts. "Jacket, jackass." She points a finger-gun at Glimmer. "Gotcha." She captures Adora really well, as embarrassing at it is to admit that in some cases.

"What do you want, and why are you wearing Adora's jacket?" Glimmer leans forward and shoves a finger into Catra's face. "If you hurt her—"

Catra leans backwards. "What's wrong with you? It's me. What kind of drugs did you guys pop? Is that the reason you made me wait for you?"

"How do you know about that?" Bow asks, always the rational. Then he says something to Glimmer under his breath which the phone doesn't pick up. Adora will have to ask Catra later, but for now, she assumes it was something along the lines, "Did we eat the wrong brownies?"

"Because you told me." Catra produces Adora's phone and ends the call before showing them the chat. She calls Adora back afterwards and stows the phone away in her jeans pocket.

"Come on, this isn't funny," Bow says. "Where is Adora?"

"I'm Adora," Catra whines. "I've got the jacket"—she pulls on the lapels—"I've got the poof"—her hand moves up to her head. "What?" she says, confusion in her voice.

"See?" Bow says, looking smug.

"Oh, shit. Is today a full moon?" Catra jumps up. "Shit, shit, shit," she mutters while pacing in a tight circle. "It shouldn't happen so early." She stops dead in her tracks and faces Bow and Glimmer. "You drove here in your car?"

“What?”

“Great. There’s a cabin in the woods. You have to take me there before it gets dark. And then you have to chain me and get out of there before I fully transform.”

“What are you talking about?” Glimmer hisses.

Catra sits down. “I’m sorry you learn about it this way, but—” She takes a hand of each into her own. “I’m a werecat.”

Adora snorts into her hand.

Glimmer snatches her hand back and crosses her arms. “They don’t exist.”

“Technically,” Bow says, sounding unsure, “that was never proven.” And there his ratio dies.

“I told them about you,” Adora says into the phone, “use that.”

“Remember the childhood friend I talked about?” Catra says without missing a beat.

“Of course,” Bow says, “it was such a sad story.”

Catra grabs his shoulders and shakes him. “That was a lie I told myself when I was little. She was the werecat inside me I tried to suppress.” She shakes him even harder, and Glimmer, curiously, doesn’t intervene. “But you can’t suppress a werecat.” She lets go of Bow and turns to Glimmer. “Please, you have to help me. I don’t want to hurt anyone else.”

“Anyone else?” Glimmer says, leaning away from Catra.

The day when someone keyed Bow’s old car comes to Adora’s mind. “Remind Bow of last summer,” she says.

Catra heaves a sigh and turns to Bow. “I’m so, so sorry.”

"About what?"

Catra drops her head. "About last summer ."

"That was you?" he squeaks, and Adora holds her breath to not laugh out loud.

Her head snaps back up. "That' s why you need to help me. Who knows what I will do next?"

Bow jumps up. "And you expect me to let you near my car again?"

Seriously? Adora gapes her mouth. What kind of friend would put their car first?

"But I thought you were my friend," Catra says, reading Adora' s mind.

Poor Bow's face crumples, and he deflates into his chair. "But I am."

Adora's heart hurts. "A w," she says, "I guess that' s enough. Let me speak to him."

"W ait a second," Catra says coolly , "I'm getting a call." She produces Adora's phone and places it onto the table. "Hello?"

"I'm sorry , Bow," Adora says, "your car isn't in danger , and you're a great friend."

Bow's face contorts while Glimmer groans.

"Y ou pranked me?" Bow asks.

"T echnically," Catra says, "it was me. With a little help."

"Of course I knew you weren't Adora," Glimmer says, not entirely convincing. "So I ask again, who are you?"

Catra extends a hand. "Catra, nice to meet you."

Bow squeaks, covering his mouth with both hands.

Glimmer asks, "Like *Catra* Catra?"

"The one and only," Catra says, and Adora hears her smirk.

"Move your arse over here," Glimmer grumbles into the phone, "you have a lot of explaining to do."

Happy that her past and her present collide, Adora ends the recording and walks over.

Glimmer's eyes pop out of her head when she recognises her. "You were there the whole time?"

"Yeah, sorry guys, we just couldn't let this opportunity slip."

"It's really her?" Bow asks, pointing at Catra.

"Yep."

"For how long did you hide her from us?"

"We just ran into each other."

"Just like that?"

Adora shrugs.

Bow throws his arms around her. "I'm so happy for you," he croaks, voice thick with emotion. Probably crying, the poor thing.

"I knew it wasn't really you," Glimmer says again and, when Bow lets Adora go, hugs her welcome. "Please keep the hoodie, it looks so much better on you than that awful jacket."

*

They chat until eventually a buff woman joins them, and Adora is immediately jealous of her build. The woman crushes Catra in a hug which doesn't sit well with Adora, and it takes her a moment to realise it's because Catra's ears and tail show she's enduring the physical attention.

"This is Scorpia," Catra says after freeing herself from the embrace.

"We're best pals," Scorpia says vigorously, and Adora grinds her teeth.

"We're roommates." Does Catra mean that as a correction or an addition? "These are Sparkles—"

"It's Glimmer."

"Arrow Boy—"

"Bow, actually."

"and Adora."

Scorpia's jaw drops. "*The* Adora?" She turns to Catra. "She's *your* Adora?"

That fact that Scorpia knows unsettles Adora's stomach. It's good that Catra has someone to talk about her past with. Really. But does it have to be Scorpia?

Stars, she just got Catra back and already wants her all to herself. She doesn't even know Scorpia, and she told Bow and Glimmer about Catra. Does this jealousy make her a horrible person?

Scorpia assaults her in a bear hug and squeezes the life out of her. Oh, those muscles. If Scorpia continues to squeeze her like that, though, Adora might pass out. When Scorpia does release her eventually, sweet air streams back into her lungs, and the pain recedes.

Catra strokes Adora's arm. They lock eyes, and Catra's face says, "Sorry, I feel you."

Oh, right! They developed a secret language just using their faces – and ears, in Catra's case – because they had to stay silent most of the time at Catra's place.

"Does this still work?" Adora says.

Catra's eyes light up. "Holy crap, it does! Shrug your shoulders."

Adora shrugs her shoulders. "Like that?"

"Awesome. Say 'arsehole.'"

"No! I will not call you an arsehole."

Catra giggles. "You just said it."

Adora rolls her eyes but can't suppress the smile. "Anyway. Best pals?"

A grimace flashes over Catra's face. "She's sweet, but she's so loud and sometimes a little overbearing. She seems to think I'm this little kitten that she needs to pamper and protect."

Adora huffs. Catra doesn't need protection. Well, she did back then. Adora throws Scorpia a glance. She seems to hit off with Bow and Glimmer. From the looks of it, they are all oblivious of the silent conversation right under their noses while they talk animatedly about a show about some drug lord that's supposed to be all the rave.

Good for them.

"You've seen that show?" Adora asks Catra.

Catra nods lazily. "We watch most of it together, but honestly, it's a little too over the top for me."

“I couldnt tell, I fell asleep during the second episode, and during the first I only stayed awake because that cousin, or whoever he was, was so annoying he drove me up the wall.”

Catra’s snort makes Adora smile, but also draws the others’ attention.

“It’s true,” Scorpia protests. “You were there, you know?”

“Sorry,” Catra says, “I wasn’t listening. Adora just…made a funny face.”

The others look at Adora who just shrugs, so they tune back into their discussion.

“Hey,” Adora says, “I live on my own, so if you need a quiet place to hide sometime, just let me know, okay?”

“Are you sure?” Catra’s tail twitches.

“Of course.” Right now, Adora would rather watch the first film on her laptop if Catra was with her and no one else. Oh, maybe they can seat Scorpia with Glimmer and Bow? “Say, where do you guys sit?”

Catra’s eyes pop out of her head. “Shit, I forgot to buy tickets, be right back.” She jumps up and darts off.

“I’m coming with you,” Adora calls after her. Turning to the others, she says, “Text me if you want any snacks, they’re on me today.” With that, she hurries after Catra who’s looking at her expectantly from the end of the ticket line.

“Forgot your tickets, eh?” Adora says, bumping Catra’s shoulder.

Catra huffs. “It’s your fault, really.”

“Oh? How’s that?”

“You never wondered how I knew it was you in there?”

Adora blinks. "Actually , no." She snorts. "Y ou occupied my brain completely. But entertain me. How did you know?"

Catra smiles, suddenly shy, looking a little like her childhood self. Adora hugs her. "hat' s number three.

"I was standing in line for the tickets," Catra says, her voice vibrating against Adora's chest, "and suddenly there was this blonde ponytail bouncing through the lobby. Each time I see one of those, I just have to investigate. Or had to, I guess?"

Adora squeezes her , then lets her go. "t' s the same with me whenever I see a Feline. Gives me palpitation every time."

"Y eah." Catra clears her throat and shuf fles her feet. "So I went after that ponytail, forsaking my place in the line. And then." She looks Adora in the eye. "I picked up your scent, that's how I knew it was you."

"After all that time?" Adora raises her brows. " Im surprised I even smell the same."

"Not the same. ust… " Catra scrunches up her face. "he essence of it, I dont have a better word for it. I mean, you look very dif ferent now, but you still resemble your younger self." She switches back to silent talk. "It's the same with scents, at least for me."

"Oh, I get it. I had the same revelation with your voice. It changed, but somehow, the notion of it grew up with me. And when you said my name, you sounded just like I expected."

"hey share a smile.

It's their turn in the line, then. Catra buys two tickets, and for *She-Ra* no less. She never explicitly confirmed, but Adora still hoped. "he seats are not close to the ones Adora got, however.

"Hey ," Adora asks while they walk to the snack bar , "maybe that' s kind of mean, but do you think I could sit with you?" Her cheeks warm up.

"Just like old times?"

"Just like old times."

Catra hums. "I dont see why not. She' s a big gal, shell understand. And I guess they already get along nicely." She points with her thumb towards the lobby.

"Yay," Adora says, making jazz hands.

Catra chuckles. "Dork."

*

They take their seats in the dark hall, the trailers playing on the screen. When the film starts, Adora places her arm onto the armrest between Catra and her. Catra does the same, and their hands bump against each other. On the spur of the moment, Adora moves her arm and grabs Catra's hand, just like they did during the most intense scenes of the first film. Catra squeezes her fingers, and it' s like Adora found a missing piece of herself.

The film sucks, though. There are too many action scenes, packed with a ton of explosions and fast cuts that leave Adora disoriented. The way the actors portray the characters lacks all the charm of the previous films – well, the first three, mainly , the fourth wasnt good, either, as much as it hurts to admit that. And the plot has more holes than all of Adora's panties together.

If the majority of the audience shares her impression of the film, this will be the last one. An hour ago, that prospect could have made Adora cry. Holding Catra's hand, though, she cant mourn the end of an era but rejoices at the start of a new one.

"What the fuck was that?" Catra hisses when the credits roll.

"Don't ask me. I feel like I need to rewatch the first to cleanse myself of whatever we just saw."

"Yes, exactly. Such a disgrace to the *She-Ra* universe."

Adora squeezes Catra's hand as others shuffle past their seats to leave, and their gazes find each other. "Well, I have nothing else planned for today, so if you're in"…

"Watching the first one?"

"Yeah." Adora's heartbeat quickens.

"With your friends?"

Adora shakes her head. "Absolutely not. Just us."

Catra smiles. "Sure. Why not?"

"Great." Adora beams. "We can take the tram to my place, it's not far."

"Oh, I rode my bike here. Why don't you give me your address, and we'll meet there?"

"Of course. I can get us some snacks from the supermarket, the popcorn was awful."

*

Adora has trouble breathing when Catra steps into her one-room flat, looking around with her tail swaying from side to side and with an expression of wonder on her face. While this Catra isn't the best friend Adora lost to time and circumstances any more, with the way she moves, the way her body speaks to Adora – it's still undeniably her.

Her Catra is here, and her heart aches.

"Oh, stars," Adora cries.

Catra whirls around, face alert with surprise and worry.

"It's really you." Adora extends her arms, and Catra throws herself into them for hug number four. "I didn't think I'd ever see you again."

"Don't cry," Catra cries.

Adora sniffles, cradling Catra's head to her chest. "I'm not crying." She shuts her eyes, tears escaping, and rocks them softly. "You're crying."

They cling to each other, and Adora breathes Catra's scent as their hearts beat in proximity. Catra's warmth seeps through Adora's shirt and sends shivers down her spine.

"You know I can't—" A hiccup interrupts Adora. "I—can't let you leave again. Right?"

Catra laughs, her voice thick. "You're such a dork." Regardless, the rubs her cheek against Adora's neck.

"Is it too much to ask you to stay the night?"

"Do you use scented detergent?"

Adora smiles and buries her nose in Catra's hair. "Of course not."

Catra crumples Adora's shirt between her fingers. "Okay."

Heaving a content sigh, Adora squeezes Catra once more before releasing her embrace.

Since the original *She-Ra* tape lives in some cardboard box in Adora's old room back in Eternia—and she has no working VCR in the first place—they stream the film on Adora's laptop. With a

selection of sweet, sour, and savoury snacks at the ready, they huddle up against each other on Adora's bed. Maybe it's the memories linked to it, maybe it's the contrast to the abomination they saw in the cinema today, or it's just Catra's presence, but despite all these years, the film is as good as she remembers.

Catra gags eventually and sticks out her tongue. "Fuck is that sour." She puckers her lips and smacks her mouth. "My taste buds disintegrate."

Adora snorts. "It can't be that bad. What did you pick?"

Catra huffs and drops the offending bag into Adora's lap. "I want to see you eating more than one of these."

Super Sour Sea Snakes. It was a random pick in the store because it was new. Adora shrugs and pops one into her mouth. It's surprisingly sweet, the stuff seems to be coated sugar. She throws Catra a look. "That's not even sour at all."

"Just wait for it."

Adora sucks the wine gum. Then it hits her, and her mouth collapses. It's so sour it brings tears to her eyes and etches her teeth away. Catra cackles. Over the lovely sound, Adora forgets for a moment what's eating away her tongue and gets some juice into her throat, sending her into a coughing fit.

When she comes to, sweating and panting, her head lies in Catra's lap, and Catra strokes her head, smiling down at her with a mixture of pity, mirth, and affection.

"Totally worth it," Adora croaks.

A plastic bag rustles somewhere outside of Adora's field of vision, and then Catra holds three sea snakes up for Adora to see. "More?"

Adora scrunches up her face. "Only if you do, too."

Catra shudders. "Whoever finishes them first wins?"

Oh, they got into trouble and pain so often for riling each other up. Adora's lips spread into a reckless grin. "Challenge accepted."

Catra wins because she cheats. She always did.

"You didn't even chew," Adora whines, lying on her back, limbs splayed, while her soul leaves her body through her eyes.

Catra, sitting beside her, looks down at her. "No one said anything about chewing, Adora." She reaches out and cups Adora's cheek, wiping some tears away, and forgotten is the sneaky win.

Adora coughs, then sighs. "I just can't stay mad at you. So, what's your prize?"

Catra's ears perk up, and she sucks on her lip in thought. When she lets it go with a pop, a smirk grows on her face. She bends a little down to ask, "Can I blow a raspberry on your tummy?"

Adora giggles. "I remember you had that phase where you sneaked up on me all the time to do that."

"It was funny, mostly because you screeched like a bat."

Adora sticks her tongue out like a little girl—which, to be fair, she was the last time she was with Catra. Catra retaliates likewise.

"Well," Adora says, "it's not me who has bat-like ears. So." She underlines her point with a shrug.

Catra crosses her arms and raises her chin in defiance. It seems she didn't find that comparison funny. Guilty, Adora lifts her shirt to present her tummy. Catra perks up, and her tail lashes out, but otherwise, she doesn't move.

"Please?" Adora says.

At that, Catra kneels beside Adora, leans down, supporting herself with her arms on the bed, and snuggles her cheek against Adora's tummy. "It's silly."

It's so warm and so soft. Catra's head rises and falls with each of Adora's breaths.

Adora reaches down to stroke Catra's hair. "Remember when we tried it the other way round?"

"Yeah," Catra says, smiling. "You were so disappointed when it didn't work. All you accomplished was wetting my fur."

"Yeah," Adora whispers. Her hand moves to Catra's ear, slowly. Because her throat is tight with nostalgia, she lets her face say, "I like your ears."

Catra blinks. "I want scratches."

So Adora scratches Catra's head, the base of Catra's ear, massages the delicate skin between her fingers. Catra purrs, the vibrations tickling Adora's tummy, and tears gather in Adora's eyes anew.

Catra understands without words, spoken or not, that Adora needs her fifth hug.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

For your convenience: The last chapter took place on Saturday, 9 January 2016.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Saturday, 26 March 2016

Adora rests her head on Catra's shoulder. Like every Saturday morning, they sit side by side at Mermista's bountiful table in her giant dining room for a breakfast among their friends. Today, Perfuma is the last one to arrive. Eventually, she takes her seat.

"Can we start now?" Adora asks, eying the pancakes that smell absolutely delicious. "I'm starving."

"You know the rules," Mermista says, and everyone else joins her, "first seat, then eat."

Adora frowns and glances around. "But who's missing?"

Mermista mumbles something under her breath.

"What?"

"Who's Sea Hawk?" Catra asks.

Everyone pipes up at that and fires questions at Mermista.

Adora can't make sense of anything and turns to Catra instead. "He's Mermista's on-off. Haven't seen him in months."

Mermista groans. "Look what you've done," she says to Catra. "I hate your ears."

"Rude." Adora scowls. "They are lovely. And what difference does it make if he's about to join us anyway?"

"It's fine," Catra says, "it was just a lame joke, and you'd know if you weren't hangry."

"Which we have Sea Hawk to thank for, then."

Catra bumps Adora's shoulder and rubs her back.

It calms Adora down. She sighs and faces Mermista. "Sorry. I do appreciate you're treating us."

"Whatever," Mermista says.

"Are you worried that he won't show up, dear?" Perfuma asks.

Mermista drops her head into her palms, elbows propped up on the table, and groans. "Wouldn't be the first time."

Perfuma reaches across the table to squeeze Mermista's arm. "I hope he realises soon what a jewel you are."

"Thanks, or whatever," Mermista mumbles into her hands.

Sea Hawk arrives eventually, allegedly late because he stopped to buy Mermista a bouquet of flowers but didn't know what she would like. In the end, he picked up a tub of ice cream instead. Mermista takes the gift and kisses his cheek, so: mission accomplished.

"Oh, and who might you be?" Sea Hawk asks Catra when he joins them at the table.

"Catra." She shakes the offered hand. "Firm grip, I approve."

He grins and flexes his biceps. "A man of the sea like myself must stay in shape."

She smirks. "Not bad. I bet you can best most of us at arm wrestling."

"Don't fall for it," Mermista hisses at his side.

The glint in his eyes betrays it's already too late. "I bet I can best everyone."

Catra faces Adora. "Challenge"…

"accepted," Adora finishes, much to the chagrin of the majority of the crowd.

Mermista slaps Sea Hawk's shoulder. "That's what you get from encouraging them. They do that all the time since they reunited."

Adora grins and props her elbow on the table with a thud, hand raised. Catra does the same and unsheathes her claws on top of it, making Sea Hawk wince.

"You may choose," Catra says.

Mermista slams both hands in the table, and everyone jerks. "You will not arm wrestle at breakfast."

Catra huffs. She sheathes her claws, but only to point at Sea Hawk. "Then I bet you that Adora can eat more pancakes than you."

Adora chortles. "He already lost that bet once."

"Aw, what a shame."

Mermista groans again. "More eating, less talking. Weren't you starving or something."

Adora giggles and, on impulse, smooches Catra's cheek before she assaults a sweet and succulent pancake. Catra wraps her tail around Adora's waist and grabs a waffle. It's wonderful how seamlessly

Catra integrated into her circle of friends. Well, she and Scorpia, actually, even though Scorpia couldn't make it today.

"Hey," Adora says around a bite and swallows. "Do you know what came up for Scorpia?"

Catra munches on her waffle. "Oh, something with her family."

Perfuma gasps. "Is everyone alright?"

"I, er, don't know if I'm supposed to share, but I guess I can say nobody died or something."

"Stars." Perfuma grimaces. "Do you think it would be okay for me to call her? I mean, I don't want to impose myself on her…"

Catra shakes her head and swallows. "Go ahead, she loves it when people care."

Perfuma clings to a strand of her hair. "Are you sure?"

"Absolutely."

"Well then, okay. Thank you."

Adora strokes Catra's back, her heart singing. It's so wonderful.

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Saturday, April 6th

Adora's phone rings while she steps out of the bathroom and towels her hair. Catra's name on the phone lights up her face. "Hey, Catra."

"Hey, Adora. Did I wake you?"

"No, you know I'm an early riser…"

"Sure, just wanted to check, you know?"

Adora's smile grows wider. "I appreciate it. What can I do for you on this lovely Saturday morning?"

"Yeah, not so lovely on our side because we don't have any hot water. Scorpia showered in the gym, but"–

"You can use mine." Wouldn't be the first time. "Why so shy all of a sudden?"

Catra clears her throat. "Oh, no reason. I don't know. Maybe I had a weird dream I can't remember or something."

"It's fine. I'll text Mermista that we'll be late."

"Oh, you don't have to wait for me, really."

Adora frowns. Something's up. But Catra will talk when she's ready. "Of course I do."

Catra chuckles nervously. "Don't trust me alone in your flat, huh?"

"I'd trust you with my life, silly. Now move your fluffy arse over here."

Twenty minutes later, Catra steps through the door, a backpack with what will be spare clothes in her hand. One look at her hanging tail and her drooping ears confirms Adora's suspicion.

"I won't pester you, but you can tell my what bothers you, alright?" Adora says while rubbing Catra's arms.

Catra goes for a hug. "I know. It's just–There's this feeling that something is festering inside me, but whenever I try to pin it down, it scurries away before I can get a clear look. That's why I think it was a dream."

Adora holds her close. "Yeah, I know what you mean. It will come to you eventually."

About half an hour late, they arrive at Mermista's. The other guests are talking animatedly, but their plates are clean. Quite the accomplishments with the plethora of fruity scents hanging in the air.

"Hey ," Adora greets them as Catra waves, "sorry we're late. You didn't have to wait for us."

"You know the rule, Adora," Mermista says, and Adora joins the chorus of, "first seat, then eat."

As soon as their bottoms touch the seat of their chairs, the starved pack raids the assortment of dishes. Adora snatches herself a pancake, and Catra serves herself a bowl of cereals. It's unusual, but at least she doesn't lack an appetite after that dream.

"What were you guys talking about?" Adora asks. "Your debate seemed quite heated."

Bow pipes up. "We were guessing who of us might get married first."

"Actually ," Perfuma says, "you were making a bet out of it."

"A bet?" Adora calls, putting the cutlery down. "Without us?" She places both hands on her chest. "I'm hurt."

"Yeah," Catra says with a frown. "You forgot the rule? No betting before here we're getting."

Adora snorts with laughter, even if the others' groans tell her not everyone shares her sense of humour.

"Well," Catra continues, "what have you got? I want in."

"The more, the merrier ," Sea Hawk says. "We agreed on this so far: you can bet on any member of our illustrious circle of adventurers, and when this person is the first of us to marry, you win a share of the pot."

Catra hums. "How is first' defined? What if two of us marry on the same day? And what moment constitutes the marriage?"

He hums. "We didn't discuss that at that length yet, but let me propose the following." He leans over the table. "Relevant is the moment a person says 'yes' in a way that is legally binding in Etheria. And to keep it simple, let's just consider the date, not the time."

"So if I bet fifty on Sparkles, Arrow Boy bets ten on himself"–

"Excuse me, I'm confident in myself," Bow interjects.

"–everyone else bets any sum on whoever else and Sparkles and Arrow Boy walk down the aisle first, then Arrow Boy and me split the pot ten to fifty?"

"Sounds fair to me," Sea Hawk says, and everyone apparently interested in the bet agrees.

"Great. So who's betting how much on whom?"

"So far, we have in favour of Bow: twenty from Bow himself"–

Catra bursts into laughter, making Bow pout.

"–and sixty-nine from Entrapta."

Adora chokes on her pancake, and Catra is there to slap her on the back.

"Then we have in favour of Glimmer: thirty from Bow, three hundred from herself"–

"Rich bitch," Catra grumbles.

"–another sixty-nine from Entrapta and"–Sea Hawk winces at that– "five hundred from Mermista."

"What?" Catra squeaks. "I knew you were loaded, but five hundred? And why on her?" She thrusts an arm into Glimmer's direction. It comes so close Adora could lick it. Maybe she should? That would be funny.

Mermista shrugs. "She knows what she wants and how to get it."

Catra withdraws her arm, too soon for Adora's shy tongue.

"She's not wrong," Adora says, throwing a glance at Bow. "If it weren't for Glimmer, they'd still dance around each other like they have for three years."

"It was a hard decision," Bow whines. "I didn't want to risk our friendship."

"Wait a second," Catra says. "Why did Arrow Boy bet on you" – she points at Glimmer again – "but you didn't bet on him?"

Glimmer raises her chin in defiance. "If I don't get him, no one else will."

"Wow. Possessive much?"

Does that mean Catra dislikes possessive behaviour? The pancake sits heavily in Adora's stomach. Even though she spends a lot of time with Catra, she still gets jealous of Scorpia once in a while because they share a flat.

Bow crosses his arms. "Well, I don't want anyone else."

Catra chuckles. "Suit yourself." She turns to Sea Hawk. "What else?"

His face lights up. "Next we have a hundred from my humble self for the unmatched beauty of the sea, Mermista."

"That's it?"

Sea Hawk clears his throat. "As I said before, I am a humble man."

Catra shakes her head and grimaces. "No, not your bet. Why didn't she bet on herself?" She turns to Mermista. "Out of money?"

"Hardly," Mermista drawls. "I just think the man has to propose, so I don't have, like, direct control over it."

"Fine, fine. Go on, then."

Adora smiles at Catra. She always becomes so energetic when she's invested in something.

"Last but not least," Sea Hawk says, "we have fifty from Mermista in the favour of Entrapta."

"Entrapta?" Catra cocks an eyebrow. "No offence," she says in Entrapta's direction, "but you don't seem the marrying type to me."

"None taken. It's a true statement," Entrapta says and shoves a tiny cupcake into her mouth.

"So why her?" Catra asks Mermista.

"Because as rational as she is with science, she defies every social rule. Honestly, who would have thought she'd get together with Hordak?" Affirmative murmur fills the dining room. "So, if she does it again and marries before anyone even knows what's happening, the pot is all mine."

Catra's frown says she's mulling this over. Then, she points at Scorpia and Perfuma. "What about you? Are you in on it?"

Perfuma shakes her head as she places the cutlery down and retreats her hands into her lap. "It doesn't sit well with me to bet on my friends' happiness. Or lack thereof."

Scorpia nods eagerly while chewing, and after swallowing her bite, she says, "Exactly my thoughts. I want to rejoice with whoever marries first without that voice in the back of my head that I just lost money."

That's fair. Adora is too competitive, though. And it's just a friendly bet, anyway.

Catra grunts. "So no one has confidence in the charms of Perfuma, Scorpia, or me? Not even in Adora?" She gestures with both hands at Adora as if she were an exhibit, driving the heat up Adora's cheeks.

Mermista shrugs. "You all are single, and from what I have heard, none of you even has firsthand relationship experience. So."

"So what?" Catra asks with a frown, intensifying her gesture towards Adora. "She's a catch. Blonde hair – very trendy – funny, attentive, tidy, gives great hugs" –

"That's my power," Scorpia whines.

"– and ear scratches."

Glimmer snorts. "You're the only one who likes those."

"And she's very loyal." Catra says, paying Glimmer no mind. She grabs Adora's arm with both hands. "She even takes you back after nine years as if no time had passed at all." Her voice trembles at the end just like her bottom lip, and her eyes tear up.

Adora's own eyes threaten to spill tears of emotion. She pulls Catra into a hug and shushes her, cradling her head to her chest. "You're so sweet," she whispers for Catra's ears only.

Catra takes a deep breath and squeezes Adora before letting go. "See?" She wipes her eyes. "So, one hundred on her. If I win, I will throw a party, but since you're a backstabbing lot, I'll only invite her."

"Thank you," Adora says and kisses Catra's temple. Then, she turns to Sea Hawk. "A hundred on Catra from me."

Sea Hawk coos. "I imagine they'd marry each other."

Adora holds her breath.

Mermista groans. “Sea Hawk! Don't give them any ideas.”

“What do you mean?” Catra asks, her ears twitching. “That's possible?”

“Don't you follow the news?” Sea Hawk asks. “They just passed a law that allows same-sex marriages. It comes into effect sometime soon.”

Adora exhales. She stares at Catra, and Catra stares back.

“No, no, no, no, no,” Glimmer says. “I don't like that look at all.”

“Do you think what I think?” Catra asks.

Adora smirks. “That we should show them how it's done?”

“Guys,” Mermista says, “whatever you're doing, stop that immediately.”

Catra's ears drop a wee bit. “You don't think it's a little over the top?”

“You know I can't resist a worthy challenge. Besides, we can annul it afterwards. The rules didn't exclude that.”

A hint of discomfort flashes over Catra's face.

“Hello? Are you even listening?”

Adora drowns Mermista's voice out. “We don't have to if it makes you uncomfortable.”

Catra huffs. “A challenge is a challenge.”

Adora grins. She stares deep into Catra's eyes and says, “Challenge”…

“accepted.”

Everyone else groans and protests and whines and whatnot.

Catra winks at Adora. “Race you to wherever people marry .”She jumps up from her chair and darts to the front door , Adora hot on her heels.

“Right now?”Bow asks in disbelief.

“You are insane,”Glimmer calls after them.

Catra and Adora giggle like the little girls they once were as they burst through the front door in the race for a pot of gold.

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They stop at the tram station, panting and grinning at each other .

“Where do we even need to go?”Adora asks. “The town hall?”

Catra puckers her lips. “I have no clue.”She looks around, then turns to a couple waiting for the tram. “The woman’s hair already greys and the man’s disappeared entirely.

“Excuse me,”Catra asks, “where do people get married?”

“The answer is: the register office, and they even tell them how to get there. Which they know because their son recently married. Allegedly, it was “such a beautiful day and such a touching ceremony.”Luckily , the couple’s tram arrives before they manage to show pictures of their whole family.

“Do we have to have a ceremony?”Adora asks while they wait for the next tram that will take them to the register office.

“I dont think it’s mandatory.”

“Well, I hope not. I dont like to be the centre of attention.”

Catra frowns. "But don't you want to become an educator?"

Adora smiles. "That's different. I have a purpose there, and that purpose doesn't have anything to do with me. Do you know what I mean?"

"You think you don't deserve to be ceremonied?"

Adora snorts. "That's not a word, Catra."

Catra gives her a stern look that makes Adora shrink. "Not the point."

"I don't know." Adora fiddles with the seam of her jeans pocket. "I just don't like all the fuss, I guess? Of course I like it when people are happy for me, but the whooping and the speeches and the drinking and the embarrassing pictures from your past – it's just too much. That feels like a show for the sake of it, not like something personal or whatever."

"Okay." Catra nods. "I think I get it." She smirks. "From the outside" – she pinches Adora's arm – "you look like an easygoing jock, but on the inside" – she nudges Adora's chest – "you're a shy little nerd."

Adora grimaces. "Is that a good or a bad thing?"

Catra shrugs. "I like it."

Smiling, Adora gives her a quick hug.

"So, what do you say: get in, get married, get out, get the pot and get away for a week, just the two of us?"

"That sounds nice, but... A whole week?"

Catra kicks a pebble around the platform. "There's more than a grand in the pot. And we could... I don't know, rent a cabin somewhere for a hiking trip."

One week in the middle of nowhere, surrounded by trees, a stream gurgling downhill into a nearby lake. Birds singing all day, owls hooting in the night, squirrels chasing each other over the forest floor and around mighty trunks. Adora inhales, almost smelling pine cones, moss and damp leaves on the ground.

She smiles and grabs Catra's hand for a squeeze. "Okay. It's a promise."

Catra smiles back. She still smiles when the tram arrives, smiles all the way to the register office, and she still smiles when the waiting number the machine at the entrance prints for them says they will be here for a while.

"Now that I think of it," Adora says while they sit down in the crowded waiting room, "I'm surprised this place is even open on a Saturday."

Catra hums. "You're not wrong. Maybe they need to accommodate for people who work all day during the week."

"Oh, I guess you're right. Don't think about that." Adora chuckles awkwardly and scratches her neck. "I guess that makes me a spoiled brat."

Catra takes Adora's hand away and holds it in hers while throwing Adora another look. "Stop talking down my future wife like that."

"Sorry." Heat creeps up Adora's face. Catra calling her 'wife' feels very significant. Oh, stars, will she have to tell Mum? "Do I have to tell Mum? Will you tell your family?"

Catra's ears twitch. "There's no need. Annulment, remember?"

Oh. Right. "Of course." It doesn't calm down Adora's nerves.

Eventually, the registrar calls them into her office.

"My name is Mara, please take a seat," she says, gesturing at the two simple chairs in front of the desk and sits down behind it in a

much fancier office chair. "What can I do for you?"

"We—" Adora starts, but her throat clogs up. She clears it. "Sorry. We want to get married." She squeezes Catra's hand.

"Yes," Catra says, "that."

Mara smiles. "Wonderful. It's always so lovely to see that marriage is still an option for the younger generations."

Catra and Adora share a look.

"It's not popular?" Catra asks.

Mara's lips become tense. "Oh, the numbers have declined every year over the last two decades now in spite of a growing population. But let's not talk about that. Let's talk about you." She clasps her hands on the desk and leans forward. "Do you have a date in mind?"

"Er, not really," Adora says. "As soon as possible?" She throws a glance at Catra who shrugs.

"Ah, I see," Mara says, her smile coming back to life, "you're excited about the law finally coming into effect." She reveals a small rainbow-coloured pin hidden under the lapel of her blazer. "Officially," she whispers, "I'm not allowed to wear these. Neutrality, blah, blah, blah." She rolls her eyes.

Catra chuckles. "She's as dorky as you."

"Anyway. You will have to be a little patient. The first date I could offer you"—Mara's fingers clatter over the keyboard of her computer—"would be the first of July at eleven thirty. That's the day the law comes into effect." She leans closer again to whisper. "I've snagged the first time slot for my fiancé and myself."

"Oh, congratulations," Adora says, smiling.

Mara waves it off. "Thank you."

"First of July?" Catra says, then smirks at Adora. "That's during semester break. We could go on our honeymoon right after."

Adora squeezes Catra's hand as *something* squeezes her chest. "Sounds perfect," she breathes.

"Great," Mara says. "I'll block it for you, then. Now comes the boring part: making sure you're legally allowed to marry." She holds her hands up when Adora opens her eyes in alarm. "Don't worry, that's usually a formality. Do you have your identity cards with you?"

"Sure." Catra hands Mara hers while Adora fumbles in her pockets for the thing.

Mara checks it and types on her keyboard once more. "Miss Halfmoon, there you are. Marital status is single, how convenient." She winks at Catra. "Born in Erelandia, that's great."

"It is?"

"Yes. We need a certified copy of your birth certificate, and the Erelandia office knows how to handle these things. I can request a copy directly from them. Unless you want to do it yourself or already have a copy?"

Catra shakes her head. "I don't. Please do that."

"As good as done. What about you?" Mara asks Adora.

"Oh, here you are."

Mara takes Adora's ID and does her thing. "And here we have Miss Grey. Also single, looking good. Born in." She winces. "Eternia City as in the capital of the country Eternia?"

Adora's breath hitches. "Is that a problem? I'm a citizen of Etheria."

“Well, not exactly a problem, but it complicates things. I expect that your birth certificate is written in Eternian. We need a copy in Etherian for our archives. And since Eternia’s a different country, I can’t request one for you. I’m sorry, you will have to do that yourself.”

Adora moans in bureaucratic pain. “That sounds tedious and expensive.”

“It can be. I’m sorry, but that’s the way things are, no use in hiding the facts. I know all you want to do is”—she shakes her fists in front of her chest—“get married already, but in the end, it’s just a small obstacle.”

“Okay,” Catra says, “what exactly do we need to do?”

“First, you”—Mara looks at Adora—“need to contact the registry office in Eternia City to obtain a certified copy of your birth certificate. You will have to figure out with them how to get that. I don’t know the local regulations, so it could be that you have to go there in person.”

Adora sighs. “Well, I wanted to visit my mum, anyway.”

Mara grins. “Yes, positive thinking. If the certificate and, thus, the copy are indeed written in Eternian, you have to find a notary who can make a certified translation of it. Don’t tell them you need the translation for a marriage. I’ve seen some sloppy stuff in my time here that we just couldn’t use.” She shakes her head. “Just a waste of time, effort and money.”

Adora grimaces. “Okay. And then?”

“Then you come back and give the copy and the translation to me or any of my colleagues. With that, we can prepare all the required paperwork. Please turn the documents in at least a week before your wedding date. If you can’t make it, you’ll sadly have to reschedule. But your date is about eleven weeks away, so that shouldn’t be a problem if you keep at it.” Mara smiles sweetly. “Love conquers all, right?”

"Yes," Adora says and squeezes Catra's hand while brushing a loose strand out of her face. In the corner of her eye, Catra's tail lashes out.

"Yes," Mara reasserts, then turns to Catra. "Do you still want me to request the copy of your birth certificate? It won't cost you anything."

"Sure, go ahead. What's done is done."

"That's the spirit."

A minute later, they leave the building. Not yet married, but one step closer. Somehow, Adora's heart keeps on pounding in her chest.

"You're sure you still want to do it?" Catra asks.

Adora stops in the building's courtyard. It is, perhaps, a little much effort for a challenge, but—thinking about getting married makes her feel... mature? Is that it, even though marrying because of a bet is probably one of the least mature things to do?

Well, the look in their friends' faces will be priceless.

Adora grins. "Let's do it. I'll deal with that birth certificate, and you can find us a nice cabin."

Catra's ears perk up. "You want me to choose?"

"Sure, I trust your judgement." Adora rubs Catra's arm. "Surprise me."

"Alright then." Catra nods and offers her arm. "I guess that makes us betrothed?"

Adora giggles and links arms with Catra. "I guess it does." Soon, they'll be married, a feat not everyone achieves, and many others have to fight hard for it. Catra and her—they just had to find each other again. Even if it's just for show.

That feeling in her chest? Maturity. For sure.

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Since they bolted from the weekly brunch with little in their stomachs, they return to Mermista's. It rarely ends before noon, and a free meal is a free meal.

Glimmer opens the door with Adora's finger basically still on the bell button. She must have teleportation powers or something. Raising her eyebrows and crossing her arms, she blocks the door and gives them a once over. "You're not actually married, are you?"

Adora waves her off. "You can't get married that quickly," she says as if that's common knowledge and snorts for good measure.

Catra shrugs her shoulders. "Turns out, because that dork here"—she points at Adora with her thumb—"was born in Eternia, it's a lot more complicated than we thought."

"It's not my fault," Adora whines. "And the law for same-sex marriages isn't in effect for a while, anyway."

Glimmer narrows her eyes. "But you're still going to do it?"

Adora huffs. "Having to work that hard for a challenge has a significant impact on its fun factor." In Catra's direction she adds, "It will be huge once it pays off."

"Yeah, I cannot wait so see their dumb faces."

"Right?"

Glimmer groans. "You're doing"—she waves her finger about—"that thing again."

"What thing?" Catra asks, then turns to Adora. "Do you know what she means?"

Adora shakes her head. "No idea." She faces Glimmer. "There is no thing.' But there is hunger. A lot. Can we come in, please?"

Glimmer clucks her tongue but steps away. "It's not like this is my place."

"Oh, but you wish it were," Catra says.

When they step into the dining room, all eyes are on them.

"Hi again," Adora calls, sits down and fishes for a waffle while Catra goes for a bowl of fruit salad. The waffle is cold and already a bit dry, so she sprinkles it with coconut milk. Her munching is the only sound for a while.

Eventually, Glimmer groans again. "They are not married."

The others outdo each other in voicing their relief. Maybe it's because they are glad they still have a chance to win the pot. But what if they just dont want Catra to marry Adora or the other way round? The thought sits like a very dry and very leaden waffle in Adora's stomach.

One by one, the others indulge in the discussion of the newest superhero film. Adora grabs Catra's hand instead, and Catra wraps her tail around their wrists.

Oh, their friends are so in for a surprise.

*

Sunday, 7 April 8

Adora dreams of their wedding day. She's late, her hair clog the drain of the shower, her coconut milk is empty and her muesli wet with dishwater. On her way to the register office, the doors of the tram close before she can leave. She gets off at the next station and hurries back on foot. Every once in a while, she spots a tail or a pair of fluffy ears, but it's never Catra.

When she passes an old video store, she enters to buy a *She-Ra* tape as a present for Catra. Inside, Mara stands behind the counter, and Catra in front of it.

"Where is your dress?" Catra asks.

Adora looks down on herself. She's still in pyjamas, and due to the worn elastic, her bottoms hang so low that a strip of her hips and panties peeks out. The panties have a hole, right at the front, that reveals a patch of curly hair. The store is full of people, so Adora tries to pull her pyjama bottoms up. Her hands are so numb, though, that she fumbles around without success. For a spectator, it must look like she's rubbing herself, and Adora wants to curl up and die.

"Come, Adora," Catra says, of fering her hand.

Desperate, Adora takes it and lets Catra pull her close. She clings to Catra's shoulders and presses her front against Catra's body to hide it from everyone's view.

"The papers, please," Mara says.

Adora has her birth certificate in her fingers. It's crumpled and stained, and is it even hers? She can't find her name on it. She can't read a single word. Will Mara accept it?

Mara takes it and files it away. She holds her hand out. "The rings?"

What? Nobody told Adora it was her job to buy rings. Her stomach churns, and the people around her start whispering about what a disgrace she is.

"I come all the way , and you don't even have the rings?" Dad says, suddenly standing at her side in a priest's garment.

"I taught you better than that," Mum says, arms linked with Dad.

Catra leans close to her ear. "We'll be late for our honeymoon."

Adora jerks awake, her heart racing and pyjamas drenched in sweat. She pants and sits up, then rips the damp blanket away and jumps out of bed. Do they need rings? Does she need to wear a dress? She doesn't even have one. And Dad. Pressure builds behind her eyes. Why did he appear in that garment? Will they need a priest for the wedding?

"Adora?"

She yelps before her mind catches up: It's Catra. They had another sleepover. It's fine.

"It's just me," Catra says drowsily. "Why are you pacing in the middle of the night?"

"Nightmare," Adora says, eyeing the spot in the dark where Catra's voice came from. "About the wedding."

Catra shuffles out of the bed. Her hands find Adora's. "Are you having second thoughts?" She sounds unsure, but it's hard to tell with her voice drowsy with sleep and when Adora can't see her face, ears or tail.

Adora squeezes Catra's hands. "No, it's just—Do we need rings and dresses? What about a priest?"

Catra pulls her into a hug despite her damp pyjamas. The warmth of Catra's body is the polar opposite to the chill eating away Adora's skin. Adora wraps her arms around Catra and sighs. Is that the first hug of tomorrow or the last of yesterday?

"I'm sorry I woke you up," Adora says.

"It's alright. I don't think we need any of that." Catra chuckles. "You watch too much TV."

Adora smiles into the night. "You're probably right." She takes a deep breath. "I saw my dad. It's been years."

Catra holds her tighter. "Did he say anything?"

"He was disappointed, maybe angry, because I forgot the rings. Mum, too."

"They don't need to learn anything, okay? But if you think we shouldn't do it, for whatever reason, we cancel it. Got that? No harm done."

Cancel? Now? Wouldn't that mean to succumb to social pressure? Maybe it's not even about the challenge any more. Maybe Adora just wants to do this for herself, to know that there is someone willing to marry her. Even if it is for show, there are real consequences. Even if it is but a game, it proves their trust in each other. She won't let some phantoms that look like Mum and Dad dictate what she does.

"I want to do it. I just need to know the details."

Catra hums. "We'll figure it out. There's still time, and all we have to do is ask."

"Okay. Thank you, you're the best."

"That's why you're marrying me."

Adora squeezes Catra against her chest, then lets her go. "I'll go pee and change my pyjamas. I drenched these, and you know how much I hate sleeping like that."

Catra hums. "Why don't you come over to my side when you're done? It's dry there."

"I will." Adora takes a deep breath, and it releases some of her tension. "Close your eyes, I'll need light."

From the sound of it, Catra jumps right back into bed, probably cowering under the blanket. Even seeing her movements in her mind's eye only warms Adora. She squints and switches the light on.

It’s still like staring into the sun. She snatches some fresh clothes, double-checking that the panties dont have a hole at the front.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for coming back and for your feedback. If you have anything to share about this chapter, the story in general or your reading experience, please do so.

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

For your convenience: Adora and Catra reunited on Saturday, 9 January 2016, and the previous chapter ended on Sunday, 17 April 2016.

This chapter is a little shorter, but the next one will be longer.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Monday, 18 April

Adora enters the office, Catra on her hand, and smiles at the sight of Mara behind the desk. Adjusting herself to a new person would have been a chore. Mara greets them enthusiastically – does she actually remember them or is this just who she is? – and they take a seat.

"What can I do for you today?"

Adora puffs up her chest and hands Mara the cardboard folder with the certified copy of her birth certificate and the certified copy of the translation. "I hope these satisfy the requirements."

Mara examines the documents. The longer she looks at them, the harder and faster beats Adora's heart.

Catra, as always, notices and squeezes Adora's hand. "I'm sure they do."

Finally, Mara raises her head. Her smile makes Adora sigh in relief. "They look fine to me. I will run them by our expert who will check the seals for good order's sake, but I don't expect any surprise." She places the documents into a tray and hands Adora the folder back.

"Thank you," Adora says. "So we still have date then?"

Mara nods. "The first of July ."

Adora clears her throat. "What exactly happens then? Do we have to prepare something?"

"Oh, that depends on you." Mara types something into the computer . "The only requirement is that you show up in person and bring your identity cards. Everything else is optional. You can bring friends and family along, though you'd need to make sure beforehand that the room we'll book in a few minutes, if you like, will fit them all."

"So we don't need rings?"

"No, you're not even required to kiss, but you're welcome to. Bring rings, I mean. But obviously, no one will object against a little kissing. Just don't overdo it." Mara winks.

Stars, Adora didn't spare a single thought about kissing. What a relief, it would have been so awkward to have her first kiss in front of an official. They'd surely know right away they are not *marrying* marrying.

"Anyway , it's no problem to include the exchange of rings in the procedure."

"Um, no, we won't have any . We just want to get married, all the other stuff is... just not for us."

Mara waves her off. "Really , no one here will care. We've seen it all by this time, believe me. I could tell you stories, but unfortunately, I'm not allowed to." She shrugs.

"So," Catra says, "we can just come in, sign some documents, be married and leave?"

"Almost," Mara says and chuckles. "You not only sign documents, you of course take some with you. First and foremost your marriage

certificate and two certified copies. Never give away the original, that's for you only. You can use the copies whenever you need to legally prove that you're married, like buying property together or opening a joint bank account. For other business opportunities, a self-made copy often suffices. And if you run out of certified copies, we can supply you with those. For a fee, of course."

Adora blows out air. "Stars, I wasn't aware how much this all entails." She opens her eyes wide and sits up straight so forcefully that her chair groans under the stress. "I'm not chickening out, it's just…"

"…a lot, yes," Mara says. "And that's not even all of it."

"Not?" Adora grimaces.

"No. Have you thought about your names?"

Adora faces Catra, cocking an eyebrow. "Have you?"

"Not really. I like my current name, though."

"Yes," Adora says with a smile, "much better than your old one." She turns to Mara. "What exactly are our options?"

"Well, just so you know them all," Mara says, counting on her fingers. "One, you can both keep your names. Two, one of you can adopt the name of the other. Three, one of you can take the name of the other in addition to your current one. Four, you can both change your name to a combination of your current names." She clasps her hands on the desk. "But you don't have to decide now. Run it through your heads, and then stop by again. If it was up to me, you'd just give me a call, but we need both your signatures that you agree on your name choice."

Adora Half moon. "Doesn't sound too bad. Actually, it has a nice ring to it. "Not that I expect that to happen," Adora says, "but what if we can't agree on an option?"

"Then the law states that you will keep your current names."

"That's fair, I guess?"

Mara claps her hands. "Right? Not too long ago, the default would be that the woman takes the man's name, and before that, it was even the only option."

"Really?" Catra asks, raising her eyebrows.

"Sounds like the Dark Ages, right? Anyway. Do you know how many guests you want to bring? We could look into your options for a location."

"Oh, er, just us," Adora says. She squeezes Catra's hand and receives a squeeze in return. "So, the simpler, the better."

Mara indeed doesn't bat an eye. "Okay. The simplest option is to sign the papers in an office, then. I won't be at your service, of course, since I'm also marrying that day." She smiles serenely and places a hand on her chest. "But don't worry, the other registrars all know their trade just like me. Are you okay with that?"

Adora turns to Catra and nods.

"Sounds good," Catra says.

"Great. Let me just enter your choice, and then you can review all your information."

"Um, about the name?" Adora says, her heart rate picking up.

"Yes?"

Adora finds Catra's eyes. "I want to adopt yours."

Catra blinks, and her tail lashes out. She opens her mouth, but no words come out. After clearing her throat, she says, "If that's what you want, who am I to say no?"

"Then let's become two Halfmoons."

Catra smiles, her eyes tearing up a little.

Adora strokes the back of Catra's hand with her thumb. "Okay," she says to Mara to divert attention from Catra, "can we just sign the documents, then? I won't reconsider."

Mara leans forward, supporting herself on the desk. "Are you absolutely sure? Once you're married, changing your name back is not impossible, but it's a hassle."

Adora nods, pressing her lips together. "Yes, I'm sure."

Mara slaps both hands on the desk. "Then I won't stand in your way."

After that, she updates all the information, Catra and Adora double-check that everything's in order, and finally sign the application. Adora's grip is strong, and her finger's steady.

"Two Halfmoons, huh?" Catra says while they step out onto the courtyard.

"Yeah, well, Grey-Halfmoon would have really sucked, don't you think?"

Catra chuckles and pecks Adora's cheek. "You're hungry? My treat."

Adora beams. "You know that's an offer I can't refuse."

*

Friday, 1[illegible] July [illegible]

"So, we're doing this? Last chance to say no."

Adora nods and grabs Catra's hand as they stand in front of the register office. After nearly three months of having marrying Catra on her mind, it's beyond the point of choosing. It became a fact about

herself, a turning point that divides her life into "before" and "after." Maybe she's still catching up on Catra being back in her life, and she needs some official proof she's not imagining it. Either way, she's doing it.

She even bought new panties.

"What about you?" she asks.

Catra smirks. "I'm not backing out of the only chance to get married."

Adora frowns. "What do you mean? Why wouldn't you get another chance?"

"Well, maybe not the only chance," Catra says, scrunching up her face, "more like I just can't imagine there's ever a person in my life I'd want to chain myself to someone by a bureaucratic act."

"Chaining?" That word settles uneasily in Adora's stomach. "Is that what this feels like to you? I don't want you to—"

"No," Catra says, holding her hand up. "We've grown together. Chain or not, I couldn't get away from you ever again."

Adora's eyes prick, and she pulls Catra to her chest. Slowly, the tension melts away.

"I guess there's no wedding without crying, huh?" Catra's voice is thick.

Adora chuckles and sniffles. "I guess not."

Hand in hand, they walk into the building and wait for their turn in front of the office door, sitting in the middle of a row of seats on the wall. By eleven-thirty, a registrar invites them in and checks their IDs. They sign the papers, the registrar plasters the label "Halfmoon" over "Grey" on Adora's ID, Catra grabs the folder with their certificate and the copies, and then they are out in a matter of minutes.

It’s underwhelming. Adora doesn’t feel any different, so what’s the hype about? Sure, they are not really a couple, and maybe her brain just needs time to catch up, but still, shouldn’t there be something?

She stares at her ID while they cross the lobby on the ground floor, runs her thumb over the label. It’s rough compared to the plastic it sits on and will stay there until she needs a new ID.

“Wait a second,” Catra says at her side, briefly touching her shoulder, then hurries past towards the exit.

Adora stops.

Catra opens the door, then smirks at Adora. “After you, Mrs Halfmoon.”

Fingers clamping around her ID, Adora giggles and skips through the door. “Thank you, Mrs Halfmoon,” she says, grinning broadly. The sun warms Adora’s skin, but Catra shines brighter and warms her from within.

Adora links their arms. “Let’s have some ice cream.”

“To mark the occasion?”

“Just because it’s a beautiful day, and we haven’t had ice cream together in a decade.”

Catra smiles and looks up an ice cream parlour called *Kingdom Of Snows* which is apparently all the rage.

“Let me see if I still know your taste,” Adora says once they arrived. When they were kids, Catra’s taste depended heavily on her mood. When she was angry and needed ice cream to cool her down, she preferred a smooth vanilla that just hugged her tongue. A sad mood required dark chocolate, sometimes mint with chocolate chips, and something fruity like mango. When she was chipper, lemon and blueberry were her favourites. “How many scoops do you want?”

Catra taps her finger on her lips a few times. "T wo."

"Okay ."

"No, three."

Adora grins. "hree? Y ou're sure?"

"Y es."

"Okay then. Close your eyes so I can surprise you?"

Catra huffs. "Y ou know I can tell the flavours apart by their smell just as easily, right?"

"Right."Adora scrunches up her face. "hen maybe hold your breath, too? ust a little, please?"

Catra rolls her eyes. "Only because you asked so nicely ."

Adora blows her a kiss, then turns to the impatient teenage girl behind the counter. "d like walnut, chocolate chip and pistachio for myself, and for my wife"–

"Wife?"he girls says, standing straight up, and abandons her task of scooping up Adora's order. Her eyes dart between Catra and Adora.

"Y es,"Adora says, turning to smile at Catra who frowns. Facing the girl again, Adora raises her eyebrows. "Something wrong with that?"

"he girl stares at them some more, then snif fs and says, "I never thought I'd actually say that, but you're a cute couple."

"hank you,"Adora says and beams while Catra mutters, "m not cute,"which is obviously a lie.

"When did you get married?"

"I didn't check the time, but I'd say twenty minutes ago?"

The girl gapes at her, wide-eyed. "Now you're shitting me."

Adora snorts. "No, we have the certificate right here." She points at the folder Catra tucked under her arm.

Lips fluttering, the girl blows out air. "Wow. Congrats, or whatever, and I guess it's on the house, then."

"Really?" Adora claps her hands. "That's so nice, thank you very much."

"Don't mention it. Actually, do mention it. Tell your friends. Best place. Best ice cream." The girl points with a thumb at herself. "Best service." She adds a fake but toothy grin for good measure.

"We will."

The girl nods and finishes Adora's order. "What'll it be for that lucky wife of yours?"

Adora turns to Catra just in time to see her ears flick. She smirks and leans close to whisper, "Close your eyes, lucky wife of mine."

Catra's breath hitches. Right, she was supposed to hold her breath, too.

Quickly, Adora points at lemon because Catra's in a good mood, at raspberry because she seemed a little down when she said earlier she probably never marries again, and at hazelnut to calm her nerves. It must be getting to her: the wedding itself, their upcoming outing at Mermista's tomorrow, and their honeymoon right after.

"Thank you again," Adora says as she takes the cones.

Catra demands hers, and Adora obeys, taking the opportunity to fold Catra's fingers carefully around the cone.

"There," Adora says. She watches Catra lick the ice cream, bottom to top across all the scoops, watches how her cute tongue carries

the sweet stuff into Catra's mouth.

Catra's jaw and lips move, face strained in concentration, surely figuring out all the flavours, the ingredients, and generally keeping Adora waiting.

Without taking her eyes off Catra, Adora tries her own selection of ice cream, but except for sweet and cold, her tongue doesn't register anything.

Finally, Catra opens her eyes – and smiles. "Y ou chose well."

Adora heaves a sigh. "Couldn't have our first marital quarrel on day one, right?"

Catra chuckles. "Dork."

Adora licks her ice cream, and the flavours explode on her mouth. "W ow, this is intense." She waves at the girl. "W e're definitely coming back." Holding out her cone to Catra, she says, "It' s probably not what you're in the mood for , but you have to try, anyway."

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Saturday, July 2

"How do we tell them?" Adora asks on their way to breakfast at Mermista's.

A devious grin spreads across Catra's face. "Let me handle it, I have an idea."

Soon after, Mermista herself opens them. "Why are you glowing?" she asks, frowning her *Mer-Mysteries* frown.

"No reason," Adora says too quickly .

"Y ou're up to something. Y ou're not coming in until I know what it is. I still find glitter in my cutlery drawer."

Yeah, the glitter-filled balloon inside the cake wasn't their best idea. They had to throw away half of the food because it was everywhere.

"Sorry," Adora says, scratching her neck.

Catra huffs. "We're not up to anything. We just had a lot of fun together yesterday." She sniffs. "With our tongues."

"Say what?" Mermista asks while Adora's cheeks start to glow.

"You know," Catra says, bumping her fist against Mermista's shoulder. "The thing where you go like." She sticks out her tongue, flicks it erratically around in the air and makes funny noises. It's really obscene.

Adora holds her breath to not laugh out loud.

"And then," Catra continues, "even though I wasn't exactly in the mood, Adora made me lick hers. It was delicious, though."

No force in the world can stop Adora from snorting with laughter now. In a matter of seconds, she's winded and has to brace herself against the doorframe.

"Adora wanted to keep it a secret," Catra says, "but you of all people probably know already, anyway."

"Know what?" Mermista croaks, all blood drained from her face.

Catra rolls her eyes dramatically and sighs. "That *Kingdom Of Snows* has the best fucking ice cream."

Adora launches into another laughing fit. It's unbelievable how Catra can keep a straight face. Only her twitching tail gives her away.

Mermista groans and lets them enter. "It's too early for your weird shit."

Catra and Adora stay mostly under the radar while they eat, though whenever Adora catches glimpses of Catra's tongue, the image of her licking her ice cream flashes her mind. How odd.

Eventually, they are all stuffed and just chat.

"I have a question for you," Catra announces when there's a lapse in the conversation, her tone so pregnant with meaning that Adora's heartbeat accelerates. She waits until all eyes are upon her before she continues. "What you do you get when you join two half moons?"

Adora bites her lip. Here they go.

"That's probably too obvious," Bow says, "but: a full moon?"

Catra grins and looks around. "Anyone else?"

"A half moon with a mass equal to the sum of the masses of the initial half moons," Entrapta says. "Under the premiss that the lighting conditions are the same before and after the join."

"An enormous explosion," Sea Hawk calls, raising his fist into the air.

"Wait two weeks and you have glowing tits in space," Glimmer says.

Catra snorts. "Creative, I'll give you that. More suggestions?"

"Oh," Perfuma pipes up, "isn't Half Moon this club in Elberon? So if you have two, you have competition."

"Or a franchise," Bow says.

"Wait," Mermista drawls. "Why is Adora all quiet and tense?"

Catra hums and produces her phone. She opens a photo of...their marriage certificate. "Because," Catra says, placing her phone on the table, "two Halfmoons make a honeymoon."

Adora giggles while a fight for Catra's phone comes about. People utter, "No way," "What's that," "Let me see," "Are you kidding me," and "This has to be fake."

"Is this real?" Mermista demands, standing on the other side of the table, arms crossed.

"It is," Catra says with a nod.

"Very much so," Adora adds, a huge grin plastered on her face.

"And the honeymoon part?" Bow says.

"Catra rented us a cabin in the woods. We'll leave in a few hours and will be back in a week."

"I cannot believe this," Glimmer calls as if Adora had personally smashed a pie into her face.

"You better do," Catra says, "because we're claiming the pot."

"But you cannot just marry like that." Disbelief, maybe even outrage furrows Glimmer's face.

A lump clogs Adora's throat.

"We could," Catra hisses, "and we did."

"But what about the celebration?" Bow asks, making Adora clench her jaw.

"You don't even wear rings," Mermista says, and Adora's chest tightens.

"What did your parents say about this?" Scorpia's voice joins the hubbub, driving an icy dagger through Adora's thumping heart.

Glimmer jumps up. "Have you no respect? Marriage is sacred and must be taken seriously."

Adora closes her eyes, the blood rushing through her ears.

"It should be the most important day of your lives," Glimmer goes on, "not just the climax of one of your ridiculous jokes."

"Our wedding is perfectly legal," Catra shouts. "Everything else is just you being petty because we beat you. You shouldn't bet when you're not prepared to lose." She scoffs. "And for all I care, you can still be the first to walk the aisle, bear a ring, flaunt your dress and get shitfaced at a wedding party."

More voices join the fight as Adora's palms get sweaty and her limbs tremble.

"Can we go?" Adora whispers, lids still shut.

Catra grabs her hand. "Of course," she says softly. "How dare you make my wife cry," she spits through her teeth, shutting everyone up.

Chairs on felt pads slide over parquet. Catra heaves Adora out of her chair and leads her into the hallway, her claws clicking on marble tiles. When the heavy front door slams shut, Adora braves opening her eyes again.

"I'll get you home," Catra says, "and then we'll finish packing. I'm sure you'll love the place."

Adora buries her face in Catra's chest. She didn't expect their friends' first reaction to be cheering. They lost their bet, after all. But did they have to get this personal?

The door opens, making them both whirl around.

"Oh," Sea Hawk says with wide eyes, apparently not expecting them to stand right here. "You forgot that," he says, Catra's phone in his hand for her to take. "And for what it's worth" – he offers them an apologetic smile – "I think what you did was very brave."

Adora sniffs and wipes her face. "There shouldn't be anything brave about it."

"Maybe not for you. For me? The mere thought of proposing to Mermista terrifies me. How could it not? I'd bare my very heart and hand her the dagger that will decide if I live or die."

Catra pulls Adora in by her waist, and Adora rests her head on Catra's shoulder.

"Anyway . . . Don't let me keep you. My congratulations. And a happy honeymoon." He bows and retreats inside. The door closes.

"Wasn't that a little drastic?" Adora asks, snuggling against Catra. Marriage shouldn't be about bravery , daggers or dying.

Catra hums. "I think I get what he meant."

Adora pulls away to look at Catra whose eyes are still on the door. "You do?" When Catra nods, she asks, "Can you explain?"

"I don't think so." Catra sighs. "You probably get it, or you don't. Just like you know a certain scent or not. I couldn't possibly explain to you how you smell to me." Her gaze flickers to Adora, then she turns her back to the door. "Come on, let's go."

Chapter End Notes

Thanks everyone for your kudos and comments, please keep sending them in.

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

For your convenience: Adora and Catra reunited on Saturday, 9 January 2016, and the previous chapter ended on Saturday , 2 July 2016.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Saturday, 2 July

Adora's mood brightens once they are on the train and leave Bright Moon behind. Since Catra hasn't told her anything about where they are going, she watches for clues in the landscape flying past the window. Over the course of their journey , the plains and fields of the rural area around Bright Moon give way to hilly groves and, eventually, dense forests and rivers cutting through steep mountains.

"The Whispering W oods," Adora breathes and turns to Catra. "Y ou remembered?"

Catra smiles. "Of course, dummy . You sulked for a week after your parents wouldn't take you because they thought it was boring."

Adora chuckles. "I sulked for at least a month." She didn't understand how anyone could call the shooting location of the most intense scenes of *She-Ra* "boring" and had yet to learn that people have different tastes.

Catra looks surprised. "Is that so?" She hums. "I thought I would have picked up on that. Maybe you're a better actress than I give you credit for."

"No." Adora smiles. "That's only because I was always better with you." She smooches Catra's cheek. "Thank you. For everything. In this life and the previous one."

Catra presses her face into Adora's chest and purrs, both spending warmth and comfort.

Without a hitch they arrive at the cabin. It has a single room with a wood-burning stove for cooking and a separate fireplace. At this time of the year, they wont need the fireplace for heating. Snuggling up close to it on the couch that also serves as a bed sounds cosy, though. "There's electricity, but the manual pump outside the hut is the main source for water. They will have to put up with a facecloth and soap or, alternatively, bathe in the lake that's part of the property. It's so remote that lack of privacy shouldnt be an issue.

Intrigued by the old-fashioned stove, Adora runs her fingers along the top. It's cool to the touch and rough.

"The rent includes the firewood outside, we can use as much as we want," Catra says.

Adora snatches her hand back as if the fire was already burning. "I better leave the cooking to you, open fire makes me nervous, and you know how clumsy I am."

Catra chuckles behind Adora's back. "True." She places her hand between Adora's shoulder blades. "Do you want to have dinner right away and then go to bed?"

"Can we go for a walk first?" Adora says over her shoulder. "I'd like to get to know this place and stretch my legs after sitting for so long in the train."

"Sure, whatever you want."

Adora turns fully around and takes Catra's hands. "This is as much your trip as it is mine. If you want to do something in particular—

"I know ." Catra squeezes her hands. "For the rest of the day , I just want to pamper you."

Adora hugs her tight. "I'm really looking forward to having you all to myself for a whole week."

"Oh no," Catra says with fake horror , "my wife is a possessive tyrant."

Adora snorts and scratches Catra's head.

Catra goes slack in Adora's arms. "Careful. If you keep going like that, Ill fall asleep right here."

"Then I have no choice but to carry you."

"Deal," Catra says and ceases all ef fort to stay upright.

Adora yelps and does her best to keep Catra standing, but a completely limp body is surprisingly difficult to handle. Because she doesn't want to hurt Catra by holding on too firmly , she lets her slide slowly onto the ground. She giggles, and Catra smiles.

"Looks like I'm too much for you, huh?" Catra says.

"Never ." Adora, kneeling at Catra' s side, cups her cheeks.

Catra closes her eyes, squeezes Adora' s hands with her own, and takes a deep breath. "All right," she says, patting the back of Adora' s hand, "let' s get you that walk."

Although it's still warm outside, walking among the trees with countless pine needles and last year's rotting leaves softening their steps is refreshing. When Catra raises her nose into the air and sniffs, eyes closed, Adora does the same. Moss, soil, resin, and sun-baked bark. If she had Catra's fine nose, she'd maybe smell mushrooms, raspberries, hare droppings, and mould.

Following Catra's directions, they reach the lake, or rather a pond. It's about as large as the swimming pool in Huntara's gym. The clear water a rivulet supplies reveals the pebbles, stones and mud on the ground. The dense forest hides the pond from view, so tomorrow, Adora will swim a few rounds. Catra will probably not join due to her distaste of water, but in the absence of a shower – who knows?

Back in the cabin, Catra cooks them pasta and a simple tomato sauce. They couldn't bring any fresh ingredients, so they will cycle to town tomorrow to stock up. The cabin's electric kettle makes it easy to boil water for brushing their teeth and washing their faces. Given how exhausting their breakfast and the journey were, they go to bed early.

Catra demands to be the big spoon as, in her opinion, that's part of the pampering she promised Adora. Most of the time it's the other way round, so it takes Adora a bit to get used to Catra breathing against her neck. The welcome closeness makes her drowsy, though, and with Catra shielding her back, a sense of safety calms her mind.

By noon the next day, after a trip to the grocery store and another walk, Adora's sweat-soaked shirt clings to her skin, so it's time for a swim. Equipped with spare clothes and an eco-friendly soap they bought at the store, they go to the pond.

Catra dips her toe in and curses. "How is that so cold when it's so hot outside?"

Adora tries the water. Yes, it's a little colder than she expected, but it should be fine if she stays in motion. If necessary, she can warm up outside in the warm air. "It's not too bad. I'm not missing out on my bath."

Catra huffs. "I'm fine with washing my feet, but that's my limit."

"Whatever you want," Adora says. She won't like Catra any less if she's a little smelly. Especially not if she will stink herself again after

as little as thirty minutes of hiking.

Catra climbs a rock at the pond's shore. It's low enough that she could dip her feet, but as of now, she sits cross-legged, gazing over the pond.

Mindful of the hole in her panties' backside, Adora strips down facing Catra. It's silly, because it's Catra who wouldn't make fun of her – it wouldn't even be the first time Catra saw the general state of her underwear – but anyway .

Walking slowly into the pond, slippery pebbles beneath her feet, the temperature drop is refreshing until it reaches her waist. She submerges her chest briefly for a few times with a pause in between to adjust to the water . Eventually, she goes all in and starts with breaststrokes. Half a lap in, Catra comes into view, and Adora waves. Catra waves back, and Adora smiles. When she passes Catra's rock, she stops, just floating.

Catra grinds her claws on the rock, checks them from time to time. Is she sharpening or honing them down?

"Don't you want to come in? It' s beautiful."

Catra mutters something under her breath.

"Sorry?"

"I said I'm good." She keeps her eyes on her claws. Must be dif ficult using a stone, she usually has her care kit. Did she forget it?

"Okay ."

The next lap, Adora swims backstroke, the blue sky and a few happy clouds above her. Since she doesn't know the pond well yet, she' s mindful of staying away from the shore where the water is shallow. When she reaches Catra's rock, it's vacant. Where did she go? And why didn't she say something?

Adora stops to look around. "Catra?" she calls when she still cant see her.

"I'm here," her voice comes from somewhere much closer than Adora expected. She must be hiding behind some rocks.

Adora sighs in relief. "Just wanted to check on you."

"Worried about me?"

"Always."

"Just having a nap."

"Okay , sorry for bothering you." Adora smiles and swims on.

After the sixth lap – or maybe the seventh, she got distracted by a cute squirrel jumping from tree to tree – the chill sets in, and Adora swims to the shore to get out. As soon as shell have warmed up a bit, shell give her clothes a quick wash.

Since it's so warm, she decided not to bring a towel. Instead, she carefully wrings her hair out, so it doesnt take too long to dry .

Catra lies on her back on a boulder in the shade of a mighty birch, her limbs splayed. She may be napping, but her ears are always vigilant. They are really amazing, and it makes too much fun to play with them.

Adora walks over. Close, but not too close – she doesnt want to get water on Catra – she stops. "Having a good time?" she asks lowly .

Catra smiles, and Adora mirrors her. "It' s nice."

"I couldnt lie on the stone like that," Adora says and chuckles.

Catra opens her eyes – and they almost pop out of her head. She gasps and hides behind her hands. "Stars, Adora."

"What?"

"You can't just dangle your boobs right into my face."

Adora hugs herself. "What's wrong with my boobs?"

"Nothing!"

Since when does that make her uncomfortable? Why? We've seen each other naked plenty of times."

"Yeah. When we were kids."

They had a lot of sleepovers since they found each other again. Adora didn't pay attention where Catra was or where Catra looked at when she dressed herself or got ready for bed. "Oh. Well, I just wash my clothes. When I'm done, I should be dry and will dress. Sorry."

Catra sighs, still covering her eyes. "No, I'm sorry. I didn't mean to blame you, I was just surprised."

Adora frowns. "But you still want me to dress?"

"Please."

"Okay. I'll let you know when I'm done."Adora turns and tends to her laundry. But something is weird. Why did it bother Catra that much?

While Adora dunks her shirt and panties into the pond, while she rubs soap into the fabric, while she rinses the soap out again, and especially while she hangs her pieces over a low branch to dry: she's acutely aware of where Catra is and what Catra might see if she looked in Adora's direction.

Quickly, Adora slips into her spare clothes. "I'm done,"she says. After clearing her throat, she adds, "I'll get started on lunch. Chopping vegetables and stuff."She strides along the path that will take her back to the cabin.

Catra sits up. “Adora, wait.”

“You already made dinner and breakfast,” Adora says, walking backwards to face Catra, “at least let me do this.”

Catra frowns. “I—”

Adora waves her hands. “It’s okay, really. Just go on with your nap.” She turns her back to Catra even though she looked like she wanted to say something. It hurts to leave, but she just needs to be alone for a while.

When did that ever happen?

*

Sunday, July 31

Adora replays the memory of what unfolded by the pond again and again. By the time she’s cubing onions, she cant tell if she cries because of them, or if she’s chopping onions because she needed to cry.

She never ran away from Catra. Not even the first day they met and ended up fighting. She’s always been the patient one. Understanding. When Catra needed space and bolted, Adora waited for her return, listened to her excuse and gave her the hug Adora always knew she was secretly asking for.

So what is Adora actually asking for? She gets her five hugs every day. What else could she want?

Adora sighs and drops the knife onto the cutting board. She takes the soap and a bowl with boiled water outside to wash her hands and her face. Back inside, she searches her suitcase until she finds her warmest jumper she only packed because it’s perfect for hiding the cat face sand mould. She found it in a cardboard box in the attic

when she visited Mum and, in secret, acqired the translation of her birth certificate.

Carefully, Adora unwraps the sand mould, the once vibrant yellow bleached out by the sun. She runs her fingers over the cracks in the plastic, brittle with age. It brings back old memories of them sitting in the playground's sandpit, laughing, trying and failing to create the perfect cat face in the too dry sand.

To make Adora happy eventually, Catra piled up the sand and pressed her own face into it. Adora giggled so hard she didnt see she-who-must-not-be-named coming to shout at Catra for getting sand into her hair. Catra cried because the grip around her wrist was too strong for her to bear. It left Adora too shocked and scared to do anything about it.

She had to play alone for the next week.

Adora sniffs and wipes her face with her sleeve. When Catra finally came back after that week, Adora hugged her for the first time, and she didnt let go until Catra hugged her back. Then, Adora made her own pile of sand and pressed her face into it, sticking out her tongue to create a funny face. Catra had the time of her life while Adora tried to get the sand out of her mouth.

What went wrong earlier? Adora sits on the floor , her back resting against the couch, and cradles the sand mould to her chest. Is this all the stress and the pressure of the wedding, the expectations and their friends' resistance breaking ground? W as Catra's reaction to Adora's body merely the final straw?

The challenge, the wedding, calling this their honeymoon: was this a stupid idea after all? W ere the others right?

Adora strokes the sand mould. She brought it as a gift in celebration of their one-week anniversary. Shaking her head at herself for this ridiculous idea, she hides the cat face inside the jumper and the

jumper at the bottom of her suitcase. She blows her nose, takes her phone and searches, "how to annul a marriage."

*

Adora strides down the path to the pond. Hungry, because Catra hasn't returned yet to make lunch. Unsettled, because "We tied to them again: there is no such thing as a "we changed our minds and don't want to be married any more" annulment. There are some cases in which annulment is possible, but this, their honeymoon, might put the final nail in the coffin of this route because it "constitutes the marriage." In that case, they can only file for divorce.

That word snakes like a rope around Adora's neck. It involves lawyers, judges, the court, and each of those pulls the rope tighter. A divorce bears the stigma of a failed marriage while an annulment is apology and forgiveness. Divorce says, "I don't want you in my life," and nothing could be further from the truth. If this is the way they have to take, Adora bit off more than she can chew.

She can't tell Catra, "we need to divorce." Panting, Adora stops and braces herself against a tree, the bark cutting into her palm. Stars, she'd rather stay married. Of course, if Catra want's a divorce, she's getting it. Only...what if they don't need to? Granted, Catra was certain Adora would marry someone for real eventually, and Catra is a catch, that's for sure. But what if that day never comes for either of them? They'd just get through the divorce for nothing.

Mulling this over on her own won't solve anything. She has to talk to Catra. Forcing the air slowly into and out of her lungs, her heart eventually calms down, and breathing comes easy again.

Pushing forward, soon the rivulet that feeds the pond gurgles somewhere hidden behind bushes, trees and rocks. Walking further down the path, occasional splashing reaches Adora's ears. Is Catra bathing her feet? The image of Catra sitting on that rock of hers, one foot submerged, the other between her hands for a good scrubbing, puts Adora's mind at ease.

Quickly, she passes the boulder that hides the pond from her view. Catra stands in knee-deep water near the shore instead of sitting on her rock. Her back faces Adora, and she's naked, glinting in the sun. Again and again, she bends down, scoops water with her hands and pours it over the foamy fur on her arms, neck, and shoulders.

Frozen on the spot, Adora stares. She shouldn't. It's Catra's private moment, and she wouldn't want Adora to see her like that. She made it perfectly clear that she was uncomfortable around a nude Adora, so it only makes sense that it's the same the other way around.

Catra washes the small of her back. She takes her tail into her hands and gives it a scrub from tip to base. Her hands stroke along her thighs, and her buttocks, too.

They really aren't children any more. Adora swallows, her heart beating in her chest.

In one fluid motion, Catra bends all the way down do dunk her head underwater and shoots up again, the water spraying in a vertical semicircle from her hair. She shakes herself, ejecting more water from her fur, the flurry of droplets curling the pond's surface. For good measure, she flicks her ears a few times.

Catra turns around, and at the sight of her silhouette, Adora's breath hitches. Of course, Catra spots Adora staring right away. She freezes on the spot like Adora did – and maybe also literally, water running off her chin.

In her mind, Adora runs her hands along Catra's curves. She shouldn't, but she can't stop, wants to press her own body against Catra's. But why? They've shared their warmth so often, before and after life separated them. They've slept so many nights in the same bed, cuddled up against each other.

She wants. She also wants them to be okay, wants things between them to be normal again. And yet…

Were the same thoughts raging in Catra's mind earlier? Does she feel this shift, too?

Adora waves, just an awkward arc of f the cuff. Catra, too, springs back into motion, walks out of the pond, shakes her legs out, always keeping her eyes on Adora. She saunters over with confidence, and even though Adora keeps her gaze on Catra' s face, the sway of Catra's hips burns bright in the corner of her vision.

When Catra comes closer, the tenseness of her lips is the apparent crack in her facade. She slows her step and comes to a halt half an arm's length away. Adora offers her hands, and Catra takes them, squeezes them. She blinks slowly , and Adora mirrors her.

"Hi," Adora breathes.

"Hey , Adora."

"Are we okay?"

A wistful smile captures Catra's lips. "You tell me."

Adora swallows the lump in her throat. "I dont know ."

A pained expression flashes over Catra's face as she turns it away.

"I want us to be," Adora adds. With one hand, she clings to Catra' s, dares to raise the other to touch Catra's jaw with her fingertips, to encourage Catra to look at her again. "Please."

Catra moves Adora's palm to her cheek, holds it there, but she doesnt look. Instead, she sighs. "W e need to talk."

Is this the end of something, or rather a beginning? Maybe it is both. "Yes, we do."

Now, Catra looks. She drops her ears. "Do you want to go first, then?"

Adora shakes her head. "My head is a mess, I don't know where to start. So if you do"…

Catra bites her lip. "Okay . But I need to be dressed for this."

"Sure, do you want me to wait for"–

Catra answers by pulling Adora with her to her pile of clothes. As Catra dresses, Adora busies herself with checking whether her laundry already dried. A quick touch reveals the shirt is still wet. She lingers until Catra voices her okay.

They find themselves a spot on the soft forest floor , each leaning against a different tree's trunk, facing one another. When Catra taps her toes against the sole of Adora's shoe, Adora takes both shoes and her socks of. Then they sit there, the bottoms of their feet touching all the way. Adora smiles, and on a whim, she pushes her right foot down as if flooring the accelerator. Catra does the same with her own right foot. They switch back and forth and eventually break out into laughter.

Adora's stomach grumbles.

Catra raises her eyebrows. "I can make lunch first," she says, her tone betraying she's not looking forward to their talk.

"I can wait," Adora says, smiling softly , "but if you're not ready , I can dump my mess on you instead."

Catra sighs in defeat. "No, I guess I've put this of f long enough."

"What do you mean?"

"You surely remember the day we started this challenge."

"I do."

Catra pushes her fingers into the layer of leaves and pine needles on the ground. "That same day , something else started."

Adora cocks her eyebrow. "Does the strange mood you were in back then has anything to do with this? You said you probably had a dream."

Catra chuckles, grabbing a fistful of dead leaves. "Of course you remember that."

"I shouldn't?"

"That's not what I meant," Catra says, looking Adora in the eye. "It's just how you are: attentive and stuff like that. But—" She chews her cheek, and Adora hates that they sit so far apart. "Sometimes, I don't know why you care so much about me."

"Hey," Adora calls, pushing against Catra's feet. "Don't talk about my wife like that. She's the most kind, loyal and caring person I know."

"Sap."

"Same."

Catra dumps the leaves onto the ground and picks up a pine cone instead. She turns it between her claws, inspects it from all sides. "I didn't know it back then, but it was the day I started to see you differently."

Adora's heart rate increases. "Differently how?"

"Well." Catra winces and closes her fist around the cone. "I started to see you as a woman."

Something tugs at Adora's stomach, and when Catra meets her eyes, the tug becomes stronger.

"There emerged this new layer between us that I didn't know how to handle." Catra rolls the cone back and forth over the leg of her shorts.

Adora grips her thighs, wishing she were that cone. "I didn't notice anything."

Catra huffs. "I guess that makes me the better actress." She drops her gaze and the cone, then wipes her pants of f. "But it stayed on my mind. It made me want to be close to you. Physically." She laughs once. "And you made it so easy for me. You never rejected my touches, often invited them, or even reached out yourself."

"That's the way I show my affection."

Catra cocks an eyebrow at her. "Is that so? You don't touch your other friends like that."

"That is true, it seems. "You're my best friend. Of course you get the most affection."

Catra bumps her fist onto the ground beside her. Head lowered, she looks at Adora from the top of her eyes. "What if I want more?"

Adora sucks on her bottom lip. She wants to say she'd give Catra anything if it fixed things between them, if it made Catra happy. But without knowing what exactly she'd promise, she could hurt them both in the end. "And that would be?"

Catra groans and tilts her head all the way back until it hits the trunk behind her. "Don't make me say it."

"But what if I can give you what you want?"

Catra's wide eyes snap to hers. "What?"

"Tell me what you want, and I tell you if you can have it."

Catra shakes her head. "I can't say this to your face."

"Then come here," Adora says, opening her arms, "and tell the forest instead."

For a while, they fight with their eyes. Adora wins.

"You'll be the death of me," Catra mumbles as she pushes herself off the ground.

Adora smiles and offers Catra to sit between her legs. Catra accepts, and Adora wraps her arms around Catra's waist from behind, pulls Catra's back against her chest. She tucks Catra's head safely under her chin.

"There," Adora says. "Ready when you are."

Catra clings to Adora's hands. "But what if you're appalled? What if you don't want to be my friend any more?"

Again, Adora wants to promise her that won't happen, wants to soothe her insecurities, but again, she can't. Catra knows her best, and if she's not convinced that Adora will stick with her, that's a worry Adora has to take seriously.

"Maybe I should go first," Adora says. She hears Catra swallow.

"Okay," Catra says lowly.

But where to start? Initially, Adora came to discuss their marriage, but then—then Catra happened, and Adora's mind went haywire. It's still a jumbled mess and not a good place to start. The topic will be their marriage, then. Or the divorce? Or rather marriage of convenience with the option for an eventual divorce should either of them need it? That's not a good opening, either.

Adora sighs, and it makes her aware of the closeness between Catra and her. With every breath, her chest moves against Catra's back and vice versa. Catra is here with her, and not just coincidentally: they are here because they want to be around each other. Adora wants this every day. After too long a separation, a miracle brought them back together, and she couldn't wait for another one should they part ever again.

Waiting. That's what she did all those years. She waited for Catra. There was never anyone else for her. And Catra should know. Adora's about to open her mouth and say...what, exactly? Her heart thumps in her chest. Catra must feel it. Her palms get sweaty, and if Catra's fur wasn't still a bit damp, she'd feel that, too.

Catra squeezes Adora's hands. "Adora?" she asks, then turns sideways in their embrace to lock her kind eyes with Adora. "What's wrong?"

Adora opens her mouth. Silence. What if Catra wants a divorce? She said there wasn't the need for a chain between them, but she said that with the eventual annulment in mind.

Stars, now she understands what Sea Hawk said about bravery.

"You're worrying me," Catra says, her voice trembling like her heart is about to break.

"Let's make this real," Adora says, offering heart and dagger. "Please, be my wife."

Catra's face contorts, and tears gather in her eyes.

Adora gasps. "No, don't cry," she cries, cupping Catra's cheek.

Catra laughs or cries or maybe both, and not knowing what it is stops Adora's heart. She throws her arms around Adora, presses her face against Adora's neck – and presses her lips onto the exposed skin above Adora's collarbone. Once, twice, peck after peck, she starts Adora's heart again.

"Is that a yes?" Adora asks, eyes burning.

Catra chuckles. "You're such an idiot."

Adora sighs in relief and pulls Catra closer. No lawyers, no judge, no divorce. Here, in the middle of nowhere, it's just them.

And a hidden yellow cat face sand mould.

"It' s always been you," Adora croaks as the tears roll down her face. "I'm sorry it took me so long."

Catra kisses Adora's neck again. "W e reunited half a year ago, Adora."

"That' s still six months too late."

Once more, Catra chuckles. Adora wants to make her laugh every day. For now, she's happy to hold Catra in her arms, to sit here, and calm her nerves.

"So," Adora says eventually , "we wanted to talk about the same thing then?"

Catra sits up in Adora's lap to look at her. "Um, actually , no."

"Oh? Then what did you have in mind?"

Catra returns to Adora's chest. "Let' s save that talk for later, okay? I think I owe you lunch."

Lunch with her wife. Adora digs her nose into Catra's hair, and her heart soars.

*

Adora keeps her arms around Catra and snuggles her from behind while Catra stirs the pots to prevent the food from burning. Given how Catra leans back and clings to Adora's hands whenever the food doesnt need immediate attention, Catra' s as content with that as Adora is.

Waves of warmth and affection wash over Adora's guts. "Catra?"

"Y es, Adora?"

"This might be a stupid question since we're married already , but– Are we, like, an actual couple now?"

Catra turns sideways and find's Adora's eyes. The smirk she tries to suppress betrays it really is a stupid question. "You usually call two married people a couple, dont you?"

"I know . Maybe it's because we're kind of doing this back to front, I have the feeling the marriage itself is just a title. I actually have no clue what it means to be a couple."

Catra stirs the pots, then fully embraces Adora. "It means what we want it to. To me, it means that you are my closest friend, my support, the most important person in my life. It's the promise that I will stay with you, even if the road is rough sometimes. It's the promise that I am willing to make sacrifices to keep us going, sacrifices I wouldnt of fer anyone else."

"That sounds like a lot. Adora wouldnt want Catra to sacrifice anything. Then again, she'd make sacrifices for Catra in a heartbeat.

Catra squeezes Adora, kisses her neck, and tends to the stove. Adora misses her until she's back in her arms again.

"But what does it mean," Adora says, "on a concrete, day-to-day level? Do we couple things now? What even are couple things?"

"I dont know . Well figure out what it means to us, alright?"

"They dont have relationship experience, true, but their friends have. What makes them a couple?

Mermista and Sea Hawk have very different dynamics, even apart from their on-again, off-again. Most of the time, it seems like Mermista doesnt care about Sea Hawk at all, but then she does something extremely sappy without batting an eye. Like the birthday party she threw for him two years ago: She decorated the house with pirate-themed garlands, bought pirate napkins, and the already

enormous cake had a sailing boat on top that had a biscuit hull and edible paper sails. She acted like her house looked that way all throughout the year.

They are kind of cute together, but all the ups and downs would wear Adora out over time.

And Glimmer and Bow? He's so sweet, and she can be, too. But at times, she's controlling, dominating, even abrasive. Because he's so sweet, he just goes along with it. Or does she treat him differently when they are alone? Either way, Adora can't imagine this kind of imbalance between Catra and her.

Leaving all that out, what makes them a couple? They go on dates, of course. But what is a date, actually? They go to a restaurant, watch a film, hang out somewhere, spend a weekend in a different city or the countryside. Adora did these things with her friends, so what makes it special? It must be the company, then. So a date is a date because you go as a couple? It sounds so silly.

Adora replays memories of breakfasts at Mermista's in her head. The couples usually sit together. She always sits next to Catra. They sometimes share food. Catra and her do that, too. Right now, Catra's cooking for them. Adora smiles, rubs Catra's back and earns herself another neck kiss.

Oh, kisses. That's a couple thing. At least when it's on the lips, right?

Catra takes the pots from the stove. Adora heaves the large one waiting on the floor on top to boil the water inside with the remaining fire. They set the weathered and worn wooden table outside and sit down on the benches, each a halved log resting on two vertical ones that are buried in the ground. Steam rises from the lentil stew, purple potatoes and yellow carrots. The local farmers like to experiment with different cultivars, and apparently, the tourists are willing to pay the price.

They fill their plates and dig in. Catra blows on the spoonful of stew hovering in front of her. She shoves the spoon into her mouth, and when it emerges again, her tongue darts out to lick her lips clean.

"Shouldn't we kiss now or something?" Adora asks, sending Catra into a coughing fit. She tries to jump up but only bumps her knee on the table because the fixed bench offers little freedom.

Catra waves her hand to tell Adora to sit back down while she coughs into her other hand, bent over the table. She's even tearing up.

Adora winces. "I'm sorry."

"You have the worst timing," Catra wheezes eventually.

"I'm sorry," Adora says again. "It just came to my mind. But you're right. Let's eat." She impales a potato.

"Are you serious? You're just going to eat after saying stuff like *that*?"

Adora blinks and puts the fork down. "Um."

Catra shakes her head, a small smile on her lips. She stands up and rounds the table.

Is she coming over to kiss? Adora's breath hitches, her gaze skipping between Catra's eyes and lips.

Catra straddles the end of the bench, one knee touching Adora's thigh. She takes Adora's hand into both of hers, and Adora turns to the side as much as possible in this position.

"Do you want us to kiss?" Catra asks, ducking her head, her tail lashing out.

That *something* tugs on Adora's guts again. "I want to know what it's like."

"Since when?"

"A few minutes ago."

Catra snorts and drops her forehead against Adora's shoulder.

Heat rises in Adora's cheeks. "I was thinking about couple things, and kissing came to my mind. And now, whenever I look at your lips, I wonder how they'd feel against mine."

"So you're not just curious in general, but..." Catra strokes Adora's hand.

"...but about kissing you in particular, yes. Why?"

"Because you never showed any interest in this kind of stuff."

Adora frowns. "Neither did you."

Catra sits up and frowns right back. "But I did."

"You did?"

Catra smiles softly and strokes Adora's cheek. "When we were watching a show, for example, I'd say, 'Wow, she's hot,' or 'Damn, these legs.'"

Legs. Catra's legs. Naked legs, the muscles beneath the fur and skin working to carry her out of the lake. Adora swallows.

"Sometimes I'd say, 'Her lips are so pretty.' And you'd always respond, 'I guess,' 'I couldn't say,' or you just hummed in the way that means neither yes nor no."

"I did? I don't remember any of those."

Catra smiles. "I figured you weren't interested in women that way, but when I complimented guys to test my theory, you didn't react, either, so my best guess was that you weren't interested at all."

Adora takes Catra's hand in hers to kiss Catra's palm. "I guess I wasn't."

"Are you saying now you are?" Catra's ears flick.

"Maybe. I don't know. But seeing you, it did something to me."

Catra bites her lip. "Seeing me?"

"Yes." Adora's heart beats faster. "When I saw you in the water. It was like I saw you for the very first time. What you became, I mean."

"And what have I become?"

It's so hot that beads of sweat tickle Adora's skin as they run down her arms. "A woman."

Catra closes her eyes and inhales, slowly filling her lungs to the brim. Her ears twitch, and she exhales in a deep moan that resonates deep within Adora. "I thought there was something in the wind."

"What do you mean?"

Catra smirks, and she opens her eyes, pupils dilated, to stare at Adora. "I can tell now you like what you saw."

Oh, stars, Catra can smell whatever is raging inside Adora. That thought excites and terrifies her at the same time. Her heart races, and she takes a breath. "Can we kiss now?"

In one fluid motion, Catra winds herself into Adora's lap, her legs squeezing Adora's waist, one arm holding on to Adora's back, the hand of the other clinging to Adora's neck.

Adora pants as she stares up into Catra's eyes. Her hands find their way to Catra's sides.

"Hey, Adora," Catra purrs.

A strange sound leaves Adora's throat, and she shuts it up by pressing her lips to Catra's. They are surprisingly soft and taste like excellent lentil stew. Adora giggles and hides her glowing face in Catra's chest.

"Why are you laughing?" Catra whines.

"I'm sorry, I just thought that the stew is really delicious." Adora raises her head, and the insecurity written in Catra's face tugs on her heartstrings. "Kiss me again."

Catra groans. "Stars, Adora, please tell me kissing you won't always be an emotional rollercoaster.

Adora grimaces. "I'm sorry?"

Catra snakes her arms around Adora's neck. "You really want to kiss again?"

"Yes." Adora embraces Catra's back. "It ended before I really knew what happened."

"And we cannot have that, can we?" Catra's tail brushes over Adora's hands, and her lips caress Adora's neck. Her kisses wander higher while her hand strokes Adora's cheek. She inhales deeply, her nose dipping into Adora's skin. "How can anyone smell this marvellous?"

Embers light up in Adora's belly. "It's a limited fragrance. I made it just for you."

Catra drags her tongue along Adora's jaw, her breath hot on Adora's skin. Adora shudders and digs her fingers into Catra's shirt. Heaving a sigh, she closes her eyes. Catra shifts on Adora's lap, her thighs rubbing over Adora's. When Catra covers her other cheek with kisses, Adora slides her hands down Catra's sides and over Catra's hips, their curve pushing her arms further apart.

The memory of Catra swaying her naked hips flashes Adora's mind. She wants these shorts gone. Adora swallows. For now, the runs her hands down to Catra's knees, slowly, to give Catra the chance to object. When she doesnt and keeps kissing Adora's neck, Adora ventures upwards again on the outside of Catra's thighs and slips her fingers under the seam of Catra's shorts. They are a tight fit, so she doesnt get very far. She massages Catra's muscles with her fingertips.

"Catra," Adora sighs.

Kiss. Kiss. "Yes?" Kiss. Kiss.

"Kiss me."

Kiss. Kiss. "But I do." Kiss. Kiss.

"Up here."

The trail of Catra's kisses continues down, over Adora's collarbone, across her sternum, over to the other collarbone.

"Please."

Catra kisses along Adora's neck, her lips climb to Adora's ear, to her cheekbone. When Catra presses a tiny kiss to Adora's nose, Adora cranes her neck. Finally, Catra kisses her lips. Adora hums. Without knowing what to do, she lets Catra play with her, lets her nibble, suck and massage her lips. Catra takes Adora's head between her hands, thrusts their chests together. Adora tries her best to follow Catra's movements. She's getting woozy, and her heart races. For a little support, she grips Catra's thighs. Catra moans, and the tug at her guts, the fire that rages inside, gets too much.

Adora breaks the kiss. "Slow down," she says, panting, her lips numb, and finally opens her eyes again to leave the vortex of heat and want.

Catra watches her in concern. "Are you alright?" She runs the back of her fingers over Adora's cheek. "You look pale."

Adora rests her head on Catra's chest, turned to the side to focus on the trees some steps away. "I think I just got overwhelmed." She hugs Catra. "But I really liked that."

Catra hums. "At every other verdict, I would have doubted my sanity."

The feeling comes back to Adora's lips, and her heart slows down over time. "Maybe I just burned all my blood sugar."

A hand stroking Adora's hair, Catra chuckles. "You should eat something, then. But—" She cuts herself off.

Adora rubs her cheek over Catra's chest. "Speak your mind."

Catra huffs. "No pressure, but I'd like to do that again eventually."

"Oh, we will," Adora says with a smile. "This is a whole new world I'm discovering only now."

"Thank the stars," Catra moans. "Now that I've tasted you, smelled that scent, I want it all. I want every part of you."

"You mean—" Adora clears her throat, then whispers, "you mean sex?" Her cheeks are definitely not pale any more.

Catra stammers. "I mean, only if you're okay with that, but, yes, I— Stars, Adora, you really have no idea what your scent is doing to me. I really want to get to the source of it."

"The source?" Adora wheezes.

Catra backs away, and their eyes find each other. "You do know how sex works, at least in theory, right?"

Adora giggles and presses her forehead against Catra's chest. "I guess. I've just never given it any real thought."

"That's okay." Catra cradles Adora's head. "We can take our time to explore and figure out what feels good for us. I'm not going anywhere."

"Well, maybe we should think about moving in together?"

Catra chuckles. "One step at a time. We still have a few days left."

Adora holds Catra tight. "And then the rest of our lives."

*

Friday, July 8

The pressure on Adora's bladder becomes unbearable when Catra shifts where she lies on top of her. She groans and pushes her pelvis into the couch to take the load off her bladder, but it barely helps.

"Stay still," a drowsy Catra mumbles into Adora's chest.

"I need to pee."

"Not my problem."

"Catra, come on, just let me get up."

"No," Catra whines.

"Why not?"

"I don't want it to be Friday already."

Adora smiles and strokes Catra's hair. "It's Friday if you want it or not, and we're not even leaving today. The sooner you let me go, the sooner I will be back." She adds with as much innuendo as she can muster, "Then we can cuddle properly."

Catra's tail lashes out. "You and your monster bladder will need at least five minutes." She sounds more awake already.

Adora smirks and moves one hand from the small of Catra's back further down to pinch her buttock.

Catra yelps and jerks her head up, increasing the pressure on Adora's bladder even further. "Wow," Catra giggles, "you really need to pee, huh?"

Adora croaks, "What gave me away?"

"Your face is all—" Catra scrunches up her face so much she looks like a raisin.

"Have mercy."

Catra sniffs Adora's neck, drops a kiss there and finally rolls off Adora. "I'll come looking for you if you're not back in ten."

Adora huffs as she stands up with controlled motions and grimaces with every step as she walks outside to use the privy. Even the morning air is so warm that there's no need for clothes. A part of her wants to stay here just to see if Catra really comes looking, but wasting Catra time is out of the question.

Done with her business, Adora opens the cabin door again.

"Don't move," Catra calls, eyes wide.

Adora freezes on the spot, one foot hovering in the air. "What?" She looks around in search for what's wrong. Maybe Catra dropped something?

Catra smirks, however. "Just enjoying the sight."

Adora bites her lip. Catra so openly desiring her always gets to her. She stands on the doorstep, supports herself with one hand on the frame and cocks her hip. "Is that so?" The fingers of her other hand

brush over her neck, her sternum and her tummy. Just below her bellybutton, she makes a sharp turn, moving her hand to her hip instead, and massages her thigh.

Catra ogles unashamed, her tail swishing left and right. She looks ready to pounce.

The sight spurs Adora's heart beat. Swaying her hips the way she learned from Catra, Adora saunters to the couch. Their lips and bodies meet for proper cuddles.

Afterwards, sweaty and spent, Adora says, "I have something for you."

Catra's ears perk up. "A present?"

"Just a small something." Adora smiles and kisses Catra's cheek. "Wait here." She gets up from the couch and takes the one step to her suitcase where she kneels down, her backside tingling under Catra's gaze. If she had a tail, too, it would quiver in anticipation. She produces the way too warm jumper and turns back around, kneeling in front of the couch instead. "Happy anniversary," she says, handing Catra the jumper.

Catra looks confused between the jumper and Adora.

"It's not the jumper, silly. And we're married for a week now. So." Adora shrugs, her heart rate picking up and her cheeks growing hot.

Carefully, Catra takes the jumper into her hands. She raises her brows, probably feeling what's hidden inside. With deft fingers, she unwraps the cat face sand mould. "You found it," she gasps, staring at the shabby thing, turning it around in her hands, running her fingertips along the edges.

"I did," Adora says, her throat tight. "It was sitting there all these years, waiting for you to return." Tears spring from her eyes.

Catra’s head snaps up, and she’s crying, too. She opens her arms, and Adora scrambles onto the couch and into Catra’s embrace where they cling to each other and sob together for a while.

‘W e should encase it in resin to conserve it,”Adora says and snif fs.

Catra whimpers and presses herself against Adora. ‘I love you,”she whispers.

Adora’s heart purrs from the caress of Catra’s words which she knows are true. ‘I love you, too,”she says, and now it seems the same was true ages ago when she didnt know what those words meant. She loses herself in Catra’s kisses, her touches, her warmth, and yet she’s not lost but exactly where she wants to be.

When they ride the train to Bright Moon the next day, a whole new world waits at the end of the line, ready for them to explore. ‘They leave the Whispering Woods behind, but the seed of their love they planted among the trees will always stay with them.

Chapter End Notes

> I dearly hope I delivered on the promises I made with the story so far and you enjoyed the interactions and how things developed. Next week, the story will be back with an epilogue as the final chapter.

Epilogue

Chapter Summary

For your convenience: Adora and Catra reunited on Saturday, 9 January 2016, and the previous chapter ended on Friday, 8 July 2016.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Saturday, 31 July 2021

Adora hugs Perfuma goodbye just outside the ballroom where it's quiet enough to talk. "It's no problem, it was wonderful to have you here. Thank you for coming."

"No, thank you," Perfuma says, squeezes Adora once more before backing away and taking Adora's hand in hers. "Our wedding would not have been possible without your and Catra's example."

"Oh, I'm sure you would have found the courage eventually."

"That's nice of you to say, and I like to believe you're right, but we would have danced around each other for another three years for sure." Perfuma scratches her head and smiles at Adora's shoulder.

"Then I'm glad we paved the way for you."

"Adora?" Catra says, coming up from behind.

Adora turns to her with a huge smile. "Hey, Love."

Catra kisses her – briefly, but it still makes Adora's stomach flip. "Sorry to interrupt," she says, throwing Perfuma a side-glance, "but I need to talk to you."

"Oh, it's alright, I was just saying goodbye. Thank you, too, Catra, for an amazing party." They share a quick embrace. "Enjoy the rest of your celebration. See you two around."

"We will. Say hello to the little one for us." They wave at each other.

Adora turns to Catra. "What's up?"

"Sparkles locked herself in Arrow Boy's car and refuses to talk to anyone. I think she has a breakdown or something."

"Bow's car? Didn't he say goodbye like an hour ago?"

Catra presses her lips together. "It seems she won't let him leave."

Adora groans. "Do you think Entrapta can hack the lock or something?"

"Great idea, I'll look for her. You go talk to Sparkles, she's at the parking space near the west entrance."

Adora hurries outside. Bow stands at the driver's side of his car, pleading with Glimmer to open the door. His voice betrays his annoyance. Well, if Adora had tried for an hour to get Catra out of a car, she'd be annoyed, too.

She strides over, her shins hitting the seam of her dress over and over. "Hey, Bow."

Bow winces when he spots Adora. "Adora, what are you doing here? You should be at your party."

She lays her hands on his shoulders. "And you should be on your way home." He has quite the drive ahead of him and couldn't stay the night because of some urgent work business.

"I know," he sighs.

“Why don’t you go inside for a glass of cold orange juice? I’ll handle this.” When he opens his mouth, she shushes him. “Enjoy your juice. They even have your favourite brand.”

He sighs again.

“Can’t you feel it on your tongue already, how it refreshes your mouth and your dry throat?”

A wistful smile grows on his face. “Juice sounds really nice.”

“Great. I have it on good authority that there won’t be any left if you don’t go now.”

He chuckles softly. “Thank you.”

Adora watches his back until it disappears inside the hotel. She whirls around just in time to catch Glimmer staring. “Open the car, Glimmer.”

Glimmer grips the steering wheel, eyes now straight ahead. Oh, it’s one of her stubborn sulks. Otherwise, she’d have talked by now or driven away instead of sitting here until someone gets through to her.

“Glimmer, open the door. You’re just wasting your and especially Bow’s time. And mine on top. And also Catra’s and Entrapta’s.”

The evening sun illuminating Glimmer’s face highlights her bulging temples. She surely wants to know why Entrapta is involved of all people.

“Entrapta will hack the car. You know how good she is. But you also know she can go a little overboard.” Adora crosses her arms. “I wouldn’t want the love of my live to drive a car Entrapta tempered with.”

Glimmer’s knuckles turn white, and Adora’s mind supplies the creaking sound the steering wheel certainly makes under Glimmer’s fingers.

“Alright,” Adora says with finality. “Here’s what I do: I will pick up one of these rocks”—she points towards the flowerbeds around the hotel—“smash the rear window, take Bow’s suitcase and give him my car. Then you can sit here all night and think about what’s bothering you.” She scowls to mask the bluff. It’s mean, but sometimes that’s the only way to reach Glimmer.

It works, if the seething look Glimmer throws her through the window is anything to go by.

Adora shrugs and walks to pick up one of the plastic stones that look shockingly real. She found out by stumbling over one of them when they visited the hotel the first time to assess if it will suit their needs. The stone in hand, she finds Glimmer’s eyes on her. She breaks into a run towards the car and lifts the stone over her head.

“Stop it,” Glimmer shouts, and Adora aborts her mock assault.

“Only if you let me in there and talk to me.”

Glimmer just yells in frustration.

Adora walks to the driver’s door. “Just you and me.”

Glimmer’s fists rain down on the steering wheel. Then, she pants, groans and unlocks the car.

Not wanting to appear too eager lest Glimmer has second thoughts, Adora rounds the car leisurely, opens the passenger door and gets in.

“You’re crazy,” Glimmer spits.

“Hardly.” Adora bumps the stone against the dashboard with a dull thud.

“You tricked me!”

"Don't fuck with a wife on her wedding," Adora says and quickly texts Catra that she made it into the car.

Glimmer scoffs.

Adora turns in the seat and leans into Glimmers space to stare her down. "I don't have all day, so spill. Why do you keep Bow from getting home?"

Pouting, Glimmer crosses her arms.

"Do you want him to drive through the night, to risk his safety?"

Glimmer's facade cracks, but so far it holds. "You know that's not true."

"So the only reason for you to do this that you don't want him to leave at all. But why? Are you afraid to sleep alone away from home?"

Glimmer turns away, looking through the side window.

Adora shifts in her seat to watch Glimmer's reflection in the glass. "Surely not. So I guess you're mad that he leaves you behind with a bunch of happy people who celebrate a disgustingly sweet couple who married five years ago but are still crazy in love with each other? Don't tell me you're still mad about the challenge."

Crack.

"You're jealous?"

Crack.

"Heartbroken?"

"Fuck you," Glimmer throws into Adora's face, and finally, her facade crumbles. "Your wedding was a joke."

It was not, even if they didn't know it at the time.

"It was supposed to be me." Tears wet Glimmer's cheeks. "Bow and me. We had five years, and you"—she stabs Adora's chest—"beat us again. What do you have that we don't?"

Even though Adora knows Glimmer doesn't really mean it, it hurts. "Do you love each other?"

Glimmer wipes her face. "You know we do."

"Then what's keeping you?"

The steering wheel creaks for real this time, and for a second, it looks like Glimmer is going to give it a headbutt or bite into it. "You know it's not easy to settle down with our jobs." To be fair, they do travel a lot all over the country.

"Marrying doesn't require settling down."

Glimmer glares. "It does for me."

"Well, you obviously can't have both at the same time, so if you're that desperate to marry, why do you still do these jobs?"

"You know that's just how it is in our field. You don't make a career by slacking. We can't just say no to the boss and expect to still have a job next month."

Adora sighs. "Glimmer, you can't tell me there isn't a single job you could do with your skill set that allows you to buy or rent a house and live in it."

Glimmer slaps her hand onto her own chest. "I didn't work my arse off and graduate as top of the class just to waste away in some third-class little rat-shop." Her bottom lip trembles. She doesn't say it, but Adora hears the words "What would my mum think?" regardless.

"Come here," Adora says, offering her arms.

Hesitantly, Glimmer leans forward and lets Adora hug her. "I hate you."

"I hate you, too." Adora rubs Glimmer's back. "You are allowed to have doubts. You are allowed to change your mind. I want you to be happy. Nobody would think any less of you if you decided a world-class career isn't what you actually want. Except for maybe your bosses and colleagues, but fuck them."

"But I love my job," Glimmer whines. "And Bow loves his."

"You don't love being separated all the time though, right?"

"Of course not."

Adora produces her phone and calls Bow without Glimmer noticing.

He picks up after the second ring. "How is she?"

"How is the juice?"

"Invigorating," he says at the same time as Glimmer asks, "What?"

"Hold on," Adora says, "I put you on speaker."

"Who's there?" Glimmer asks, extracting herself from Adora's one-armed embrace.

"Hi, Glim," Bow says.

Glimmer freezes.

"I have a question," Adora says. "How many bedrooms do you want your family home to have?"

"Five," he says without missing a beat. "One master bedroom, two or three for kids and one or two guestrooms."

"And where would you want to live?"

"I was in Maymore last year at a client's. A lovely little town and not too far from Bright Moon."

"How's the rent?"

"Affordable, I'd say."

"You've looked into it?" Adora smirks in Glimmer's direction who still looks like a deer in headlights.

"Well, I had a little chat with the client about it during a break."

"Are you happy with your job?"

For the first time, a stretch of silence fills the car. "I do important work."

Adora raises her eyebrows at Glimmer who snaps out of it and looks into her lap. "Could you do important work in Maymore, too?"

"Of course. Maybe on a smaller scale, but these people are important, too."

"Finish your juice, Bow," Adora says with a smile, "Glimmer needs a ride home."

"Okay, I will."

Adora ends the call. "Glimmer, if you want something, open your mouth. If you need advice, ask him. Talk to each other. Bow can't read your mind. That doesn't mean he loves you any less."

Glimmer pouts. "But you and Catra can read minds."

Adora laughs. "No, we can't."

"You have this thing with your faces."

"Be thankful you never needed it."

Bow knocks on Glimmer's window, startling her.

"Get home safely ," Adora says, "thank you for coming, and well find a way to get you your car. Goodbye." She picks up the plastic stone from where it tumbled onto the floor and gets out before Glimmer has the chance to protest, then waves Bow goodbye. Only when she has placed the stone back to its place and stepped inside, she allows herself to groan.

Somehow, that summons Mermista. "Oh, hey ."

"Hi." Adora cocks an eyebrow at the stressed vibes Mermista gives off. "Something wrong?"

"Have you seen Sea Hawk somewhere?"

Adora groans again. Not another relationship problem.

"Hey ," Mermista says, "that' s my thing."

"What?"

"Te groaning."

Adora blinks. "Whatever . What happened between the two of you?"

"Happened?" Mermista frowns. "Nothing. W e just have a little thing planned, and I cant find him. I sent him of f to fetch something, and he hasnt returned and doesnt answer his stupid phone."

"Y ou have a thing planned?" Adora says, beaming.

"Dnt get too excited." Mermista shrugs. "Maybe you can help me look? Ill check the bar again, can you check the pool?"

Adora's excitement dissipates. "Sure," she sighs. "Throwing a party this large is really exhausting. Maybe she just stays at the pool a little. She could invite Catra. All guests staying the night have access to it, but right now, it's probably empty.

With a spring in her step, she heads to the pool. It's some distance away from the ballroom, all on the other side of the hotel. Along the hallway, she discovers red spots on the tiled floor. Is that blood? She gasps. Did Sea Hawk hurt himself?

Adora breaks into a run. She bolts around the final corner, and almost slams into Catra. "Catra," she calls out in surprise. Stars, the blood isn't hers, is it? Are you okay?" She scans Catra for injuries.

"I'm fine," Catra says, stopping Adora's antics by gripping her shoulders. "But what are you doing here?"

"I'm looking for Sea Hawk. Mermista couldn't find him, but then I saw the blood." Adora points to the floor where the drops lead to the door.

Catra rolls her eyes affectionately. "That's not blood."

Adora raises her eyebrows. "How do you—" Of course, the scent. "Ah, silly me." She smooches Catra's cheek. "Wait, if that isn't blood, what brings you here?"

Catra huffs. "It just so happens that Mermista told me you were waiting here for me. For a little fun." She waggles her brows.

Adora bites her lip. "As much as I'm down for that, if Mermista is involved, we better don't get anything started."

"True. I wouldn't put it past her to hide some cameras."

Adora straightens her back. "Why do you think she wanted us to be here?"

Catra shrugs. "Probably to follow the fake blood."

"Oh! Is this a puzzle? She said they had planned something."

"Your guess is as good as mine."

"Then I guess we have to get to the other side." Adora places the sides of her hands against the glass door and tries to see what lies beyond, but it's too dark to make out more than a few tiles in the shine of the hallway lighting. She turns back to Catra. "I guess you already tried your keycard?"

Catra smirks. "What do you take me for, an amateur?"

Adora smiles. "I'll try mine for good measure. Maybe Mermista knew I'd arrive after you." She produces her keycard from the small pouch sewn into her dress and holds it against the scanner. With a beep, the orange LED lamp turns green, and the door's lock snaps open. Adora coos. "Are you excited?"

Catra chuckles and pulls the door open. "After you, Mrs Halfmoon."

Adora smooches her again. "Thank you, Mrs Halfmoon." She steps inside and fumbles in the dark for a light switch.

A moment later, a distant click reaches Adora's ear, and the overhead lights flicker to life. Catra's awesome eyes never fail to amaze her.

An inflatable boat floating in the pool's centre dominates the room. A tarpaulin covers the boat, but what looks like a person's leg sticks out. The foot dangles into the water, sending ripples out with every little twitch.

Adora's skin tingles with anticipation. "I'll get the boat," she says and starts to lift her dress, but Catra catches her hand.

"I won't let you strip here when there is definitely at least one camera recording our every step."

"Right." Adora's cheeks heat up, and she drops her hands. "What do we do, then?"

Catra shrugs. "There's always a surface current in a pool like this. Since the boat sits right there in the centre, just waiting for us, something holds it in place. If it's a rope, we can pull the boat in."

"That makes sense. Adora smiles at Catra's wit and examines the pool more closely. "I don't see any ropes."

"Maybe it's a fishing line, that's hard to spot. It must be attached to something, check the drain grates around the pool."

"Okay."

Catra nods. "Let's split up."

"No," Adora calls and grabs Catra's hand. "People die when someone says that."

Catra smiles. "Alright, then lead the way, Detective Halfmoon."

"If I'm the detective, who are you? The commissioner?"

"No, they keep their hands clean." Catra smirks. "I'm the person who beats everyone up who wants to harm the detective."

Adora bites her lip. "You're sure there are cameras here?"

Catra chuckles and kisses Adora.

"Let's do it this way: I feel around in the water, and you check the grates."

Catra agrees, and so they make their way around the pool. To their chagrin, they come up empty-handed. "Well, it was worth a try. Let's check the rest of the room. There must be something."

The room, though, is utterly bare: no windows, just naked tiles on each wall, only broken by the door they came through and one on the other side of the pool with the label "Maintenance."

"Let' s check that door," Adora says, and they head over . It's locked, and without a keypad or an apparent scanner for their cards, they need a key.

"Help me up," Catra says, "maybe there' s something on top of the door dampener."

"Good call." Adora interlaces her fingers for Catra to step on. When Catra reaches for the top, her shirt slides up and bears a strip of fur. Naturally, Adora cant resist to kiss the spot.

Catra giggles. "That tickles, dont make me fall."

"I had to," Adora pouts. "And you'd land on your feet, anyway ."

Catra smacks her tail into Adora's face, causing her to yelp, so Adora tickles Catra's sole with her little finger. "Stop it," Catra laughs, squirming, so Adora stops, grinning widely .

"Is something there?"

"Y es," Catra calls, then jumps down. "Look." She holds out what looks like a memory stick, just very flat and without the plug. It does have a protruding circle on it, though.

"A button?" Adora asks.

Catra offers her the thing. "T ry it."

Adora smiles at Catra, then takes the gizmo and pushes on the circle. It yields, a button indeed, and a low buzzing reaches her ears. They turn towards the boat as one. A stream of water shoots out from under it.

Catra chuckles. "Oh, this is so Entrapta' s work. I love it."

"Come on, it' s going the other way." Adora grabs Catra' s hand, and they hurry around the pool. She makes grabby hands at the boat long before it reaches the edge, much to Catra's amusement. Finally,

she gets a hold of the boat and pulls it onto the pool's edge to secure it. "Do you want to lift the cover?"

"Let's do it together. On three." Catra looks Adora in the eye. "That's Sea Hawk in there. Let's pull on two and scream."

Adora suppresses a giggle and nods her okay.

Catra grabs one corner of the cover, Adora the other.

"Ready?"

"Ready."

"One. Two."

With all her might. Adora tugs at the cover and screams like the Horde soldiers in *She-Ra* when they rushed into battle after drinking a rage potion. Poor Sea Hawk shrieks like a child, but soon, they all dissolve into giggles.

"Look," Catra chuckles, "you resurrected the victim."

Sea Hawk tries to play dead again, and it would be convincing, given the sword sticking out of his chest and the blood soaking his pretty pirate shirt, but he can't keep his face still.

Adora snorts. "Probably just the nerves. Poor pirate." She pats Sea Hawk's knees.

"Too bad. We could have asked him who murdered him."

"Oh, dear ghost of this proud pirate," Adora calls out into the room, "who murdered you?"

Silent giggles rock Sea Hawk's body.

"Well, I guess we have to do it by the books then."

"Here," Catra says, "there's something in his breast pocket." She fishes it out. It's a folded piece of paper. A classic. She hands it over to Adora and pulls her sideways into a hug.

Adora unfolds the paper. It's a full-page print of what looks like a book cover, and indeed, on the top half stands *Meer-Mysteries*, and on the bottom, *Catradora Fiction*. Adora squeals and calls, "I love you guys," into the room.

Sea Hawk clears his throat and, when Adora looks, points to his red neckerchief. In the centre of it sits a little dark circle, like a lens.

Adora grins, holds the paper to her chest and bends down to speak into the lens, "I love you guys."

Catra kisses Adora's cheek. "We still don't have a clue who killed our pirate."

"Then let's find out. Together."

Chapter End Notes

> And that's it. Thank you everyone for your reading and for your lovely comments, they make me happy.
>
> If you have any final thoughts on the story, please share: did I answer your questions? Was the ending satisfying? Do think there is something missing? Your feedback helps me to improve.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!